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Navigating the UX Field in the Post-COVID Era: Stakeholder Dynamics and the Informal Tactics of UX Professionals in Corporate Environments

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Abstract: This master's thesis examines how UX professionals, especially the ones focusing on Enterprise UX, can sustain influence in engineering-driven organizations at a time when AI increasingly automates visible outputs such as UI variants or copy. The research adopts an abductive approach, combining semi-structured interviews with UXers, ethnographic observations, and an exploratory prototype.

Findings show that close collaboration with first-ring stakeholders (engineers, product managers, designers) is generally constructive, while friction arises with second- and third-ring roles (sales, marketing, operations) who favor concise, quantitative evidence. Informal "bridge builders" play a key role in carrying UX priorities across silos.

To address these dynamics, the thesis introduces *Enterprise UX Negotiation Cards*, a prototype that supports alignment, onboarding, and preparation for high-stakes conversations. The work concludes that negotiation and stakeholder management are central for safeguarding UX influence and for advancing Industry 5.0's human-centric agenda.

Keywords: User Experience, Enterprise UX, internal negotiation, stakeholders, Industry 5.0, Artificial Intelligence.

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1 Introduction

The hypothetical stumbling, my Newton's apple moment, happened on the very day a 10% round of lay-offs hit the company where I was doing my internship. The UX designer in the company, my manager at the time, was included. I remember a line from him while I was his intern, close to this:

„They laid off the previous UXer because he was not efficient enough according to them. They did not like it and wanted someone who will provide data. That is when they hired me, and why I am trying to be as data-driven as possible. "

He was organising weekly testing sessions with measurable outcomes, delivering results and insights, and keeping stakeholders engaged by inviting them to regular meetings. Yet, somehow, the typical workflow of a UXer was still not considered sufficiently valuable within the overall product-creation process. When his role was later taken over by a severely reduced team from the sister company, now placed under marketing, a deep reservoir of user insight and product knowledge (built over years of experience and involvement across different projects) was lost, and the other team also lost much of its previous autonomy. I could not help but wonder: how could his work, no matter how good the research was and how many indicators were measured, still be considered not enough? That experience crystallised the central puzzle that drives this thesis and the inquiry that follows?

1.1 The post-COVID-19 Changes in the Field

In late 2022, ChatGPT was released (Thorbecke, 2023), and it changed more than many people initially anticipated. What began as a conversational tool that was not always accurate quickly accelerated market demand for adjacent capabilities. Within months, image-generation systems and a growing ecosystem of AI-enabled products emerged, and today there is a seemingly endless range of tools that automate parts of many workflows, including aspects of software design.

Artificial intelligence sits alongside robots, biotechnology, and the internet as one of the defining technologies of the fourth industrial revolution, often referred to as Industry 4.0 (Ziatdinov et al., 2024). At the same time, there is an ongoing discussion about Industry 5.0, which, while building on similar technologies, emphasizes a shift toward a more human-centered industry and society that values general welfare beyond purely economic or ergonomic objectives (Dehbozorgi et al., 2024). The interpretation of these *revolutions* depends on definitions and regional context, and some sources argue they can co-exist. Nevertheless, within only a few years of ChatGPT's release we have seen significant changes in the job market, particularly in technology, compounded by growing geopolitical instability and other economic factors (McDade, 2025). UX roles are not exempt from these dynamics.

A role that was highly in demand shortly after the COVID-19 outbreak — when many companies invested heavily in digital product development — has been hit hard by these converging forces. The wave of tech layoffs originated in the United States and is now visible in Europe, including Denmark. This occurs in a period when new technologies, such as AI, can give the impression that the "human" in the design process is disappearing.

This rapid shift in attitudes is pushing UXers (here meaning any title connected to User Experience, including researchers, designers, and engineers) to feel that they must continually prove their worth at work, especially compared with the demand during the COVID-19 period (e.g., Kruse, 2020). What might have been sufficient, or even highly sought after by companies a few years ago, may now be considered inadequate.

At the same time, LinkedIn, being a jobs-focused social platform, is flooded with "actionable" advice for people in the field. Much of it is entangled with self-focused interests, such as promoting an online course or a personal business. Combined with rising numbers of laid-off professionals and ongoing changes in the field, this environment can create a sense of helplessness and negativity that appears to spread across the community (Moran et al., 2025).

Even with all this advice, it can be difficult to work out the “right” steps, especially for people entering the field who are trying to understand the reality of UX work in tougher times. This challenge is particularly visible in Denmark, a country known for its design culture (Hjort et al., 2025) and relatively flat hierarchies (Country Comparison Tool, n.d.). With a long history of user-centered approaches and an explicit orientation toward values associated with Industry 5.0, Julie Hjort (2025), Deputy Director of the Danish Design Center (DDC), argues that design can make a difference precisely in uncertain periods and can help companies navigate economically challenging conditions. According to the DDC’s *Design Delivers 2025* survey of 600 Danish companies, the earlier design is involved in projects and processes, the more value it tends to create for the company overall (Melander, 2025).

Taken together, these observations raise a central puzzle for this thesis: if design involvement is associated with greater value when engaged early, why does the current labor market and organizational climate for UX seem to move in the opposite direction? In other words, how do we reconcile these positive claims about design’s contribution with the broader trend that many UX professionals are experiencing in practice?

1.2 Identified Gap and Research Questions

There has been plenty of research on the challenges faced by UXers and adjacent roles throughout the history of the field. However, much of this work culminates in fairly generic recommendations, for example: involve stakeholders early in the process (Gorichanaz, 2025), network across the company (Levy, 2015), or, more recently, connect your research to the ROI – return on investment (Moran, 2024). While these guidelines are broadly helpful, they rarely address the day-to-day realities: how to elicit real willingness from stakeholders to participate, how to keep collaborators engaged beyond a single workshop, and how to ensure that insights are not forgotten as a note in a system, but actually translated into decisions and shipped changes so that design can demonstrably deliver the value promised at hiring.

This thesis therefore takes a deep dive into practical, everyday practices among experienced Danish UXers working in relatively large companies. It examines how they maintain influence with stakeholders during a period marked by economic pressure and rapid technological shifts, especially around artificial intelligence. It asks with which professions it is hardest — or easiest — to move insights forward; how findings and recommendations are adapted for different audiences; and which moments in the chain from research to implementation tend to stall or break down.

Once these patterns are clearer, the thesis aims to identify actionable ways that such insights can assist other UXers, with particular attention to early-career practitioners entering Enterprise UX, where formal authority and perceived influence do not always align. In addition, it reflects on what these practices might signal about the near-term direction of UX work more generally. Accordingly, the main research questions are as follows:

1. **Stakeholder landscape and influence points.**
   What are the internal stakeholders that UX professionals collaborate with in Enterprise settings, and is there any stakeholder group with whom they experience the most persistent setbacks or, conversely, the strongest support?
2. **Coping strategies and obstacles in the current environment.**
   How are UXers dealing with today's conditions (economic pressure, organizational shifts, and AI)? What are their biggest obstacles when attempting to move research outcomes forward into decisions and implementation, and what are their day-to-day strategies for overcoming these obstacles?
3. **Practical guidance and designable supports.**
   What concrete practices help raise and maintain trust and influence across departments, and what, if anything, can be designed (e.g., tools, artifacts, frameworks) to support UXers in building and sustaining that influence?

1.3 Structure of the Thesis

This thesis is structured as follows. Chapter 1 motivates the topic and frames its relevance. Chapter 2 develops the conceptual base, clarifying key terms and positioning Enterprise versus Consumer UX to provide the foundation for later analysis. Chapter 3 (The Process) outlines the methodological approach and the creative planning behind it, combining abductive reasoning with the concrete procedures used (sampling, interviews, and the stakeholder-mapping instrument). Chapter 4 presents and analyses the main findings. Chapter 5 builds on those findings by exploring how they can be addressed through design, including proposed interventions and brief commentary from participating designers. Chapter 6 offers the discussion, integrating results across research questions, noting limitations, and drawing implications for practice. Chapter 7 states the overall contribution and provides a short outlook on future directions. Most visual materials, the completed maps, and full interview transcripts are provided in the appendices.

2 Literature Review

User Experience is widely credited as a term coined by Don Norman (Kaplan, 2024), who became the first person to hold a job title including “User Experience” while at Apple in the 1990s. At that time, he worked as part of the three-member User Experience Architects Office (Don Norman, Co-founder and Board Member of Nielsen Norman Group, 2025; Norman, 2016). A highly cited source for the origin of the term is Peter Merholz’s (1998) account of an email conversation with Norman, in which Norman explained:

“I invented the term because I thought Human Interface and usability were too narrow: I wanted to cover all aspects of the person’s experience with a system, including industrial design, graphics, the interface, the physical interaction, and the manual. Since then, the term has spread widely, so much so that it is starting to lose its meaning.”

An article on what appears to be Merholz’s personal website suggests that even soon after its introduction, the term’s breadth created confusion, something Norman himself has repeatedly voiced dissatisfaction about. He argues that many professionals misuse UX by limiting it to the design of websites or apps, which is more accurately addressed by UI, or User Interface (Norman & Nielsen, 1998). As Norman clarified in 2016:

“It is everything — the way you experience the world, the way you experience your life, the way you experience the service, or, yeah, an app or a computer system. But it’s a system — that’s everything.” (Norman, 2016).

This perspective reinforces the distinction between UX and UI and highlights the wider scope that UX intends to cover across products, services, and contexts.

Today, the Nielsen-Norman Group defines UX as “the holistic relationship — encompassing perceptions, emotions, and interactions — between a person and a product, service, or company” (Kaplan, 2024). In current practice there are many sub-categories of roles, such as UX Designer, UX Researcher, and UX Engineer. For clarity

and brevity in this thesis, I use UXer as an umbrella term to refer to practitioners across these roles who contribute to shaping user experience.

Although the title *User Experience* may sound modern in the context of software and smart products, the underlying idea of designing products and environments to fit human nature and behaviour has a much longer history. Many early efforts were rooted in workplace settings and the pursuit of efficiency, or in broader attempts to enhance the quality of surroundings. One early example often cited is the Chinese philosophy of Feng Shui, which focuses on creating harmony between human beings and their environment (Shen et al., 2016; Vinney, 2025). Another notable step toward what we might now recognize as a user-experience profession was the hiring of a psychologist at Bell Laboratories to collaborate on telephone innovations in 1945, bringing human factors directly into product development (Nielsen, 2017). Together, these strands show that while the label *UX* is relatively recent, its ambitions and practices build on a longstanding tradition of aligning technology with human needs.

2.1 The UX Approaches Differ Based on the Product

In more recent practice, two main streams of what we now call UX design are visible, echoing older IT distinctions between “enterprise” and “consumer” appliances. Enterprise contexts include, for example, a company-owned laptop with work software installed; consumer contexts include a worker’s personal mobile phone. Because the contexts differ from the user’s point of view, it is reasonable to apply a similar division to UX practice: Enterprise UX and Consumer UX (Dambra et al., 2022).

Since these terms are not always clearly defined in professional literature, it is helpful to borrow the familiar business-model distinctions of B2B (business-to-business) and B2C (business-to-consumer) to clarify usage (Feike & Rösch, 2023). In UX terms, this highlights whether the purchaser is representing a company and often buying for someone else who will be the actual user (B2B), or whether the buyer is the same person as the user and is purchasing for personal benefit (B2C). This still does not exhaust the options. Many UX practitioners design internal tools for employees, where approaches

and expectations differ from external or outward-facing products (Steele Consulting, 2023; SAP & Blankenship, 2019).

On popular practitioner platforms — such as UX Collective on Medium (He, 2021), LinkedIn discussions (Weinberg, 2022), and YouTube channels aimed at UX audiences (Questions, 2023) — creators are already adapting and using these terms in practice, which could be represented by a simple diagram (**Figure 1**):

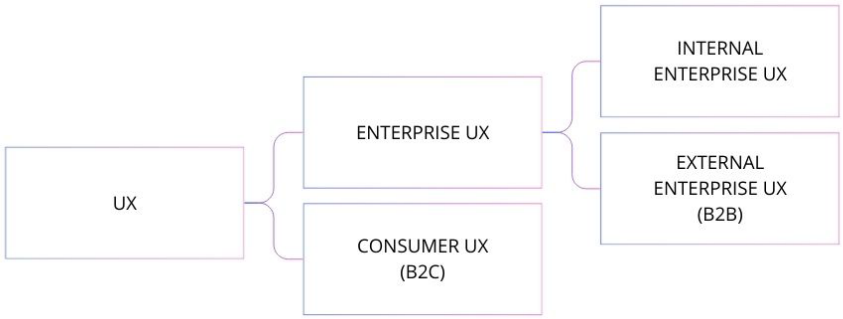


Figure 1. *A division schema used in this thesis. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

Even if the terminology is not yet fully standardized in academic sources, examples of this division appear online. For instance, **Figure 2** focuses on the business point of view:

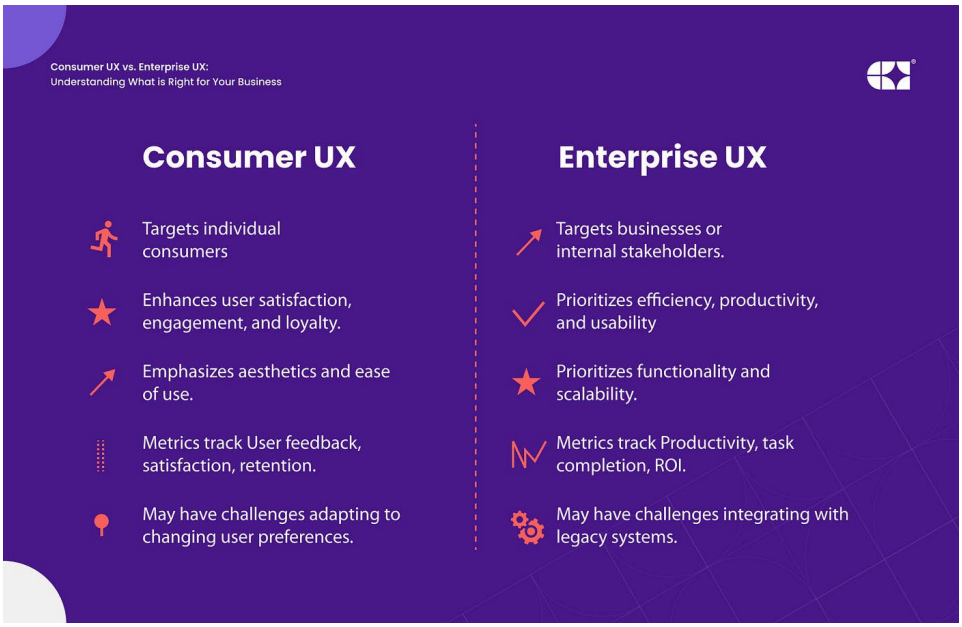


Figure 2. *Division by one of the agencies online. Enyata, 2025. Source: (Consumer UX Vs Enterprise UX: Which Is Right for Your Business?, 2025)*

For this thesis, I define and use the terms as follows:

- **Enterprise UX:** Products or workflows used in work settings where users are highly knowledgeable in a specific domain (UX Questions, 2023b).
- **Internal Enterprise UX**: Internal tools used within a company for work-related purposes; they are not sold externally, and the users are domain experts (UX Questions, 2023b; Piqueras, 2025).
- **External Enterprise UX (B2B)**: Products sold to other companies for work-related purposes. A selected few typically decide on the purchase for an organization, while the end users are domain experts (hence B2B, as the product is marketed to companies rather than individuals) (UX Questions, 2023a; UX Questions, 2023b; Piqueras, 2025).
- **Consumer UX (B2C)**: Products sold to general consumers without assumed domain expertise. The consumer decides on the purchase and is usually also the end user (hence B2C) (UX Questions, 2023a; UX Questions, 2023b).

  These working definitions are used throughout the thesis to keep the discussion consistent when comparing contexts, decision pathways, and the kinds of evidence that persuade stakeholders in each setting.

2.2 Internal Negotiation in Consumer UX vs Enterprise UX

Consumer-facing UX is probably what many people picture when they hear terms like UX or UI, and it is also where the two often seem to blend. In this setting, the consumer is typically the same person as the user, so usability and overall experience have a direct and visible impact on revenue. That link can place designers in a relatively favorable position within the company. Organizations can instrument products with tools such as Mixpanel (Mixpanel – Digital Analytics Platform, 2025) or Google Analytics (Google

Analytics, n.d.) to track funnels and real customer behavior, which provides arguments backed by quantitative, real-world data. Because the user (US) and the customer are usually the same person, there is also a more direct connection to Sales (SA) and to UX, with a Product Manager (PM) or similar role integrating these insights, placing the perceived value of UX potentially high (see **Figure 3**). In practice, a symbiotic relationship between Consumer UX, UI, and revenue growth has been observed by Pallavi et al. (2023) and by Myagkova (2024).

By contrast, the literature contains less focused discussion of Enterprise UX. Jakob Nielsen of the Nielsen Norman Group (NN/g) identified Enterprise UX as a long-overdue

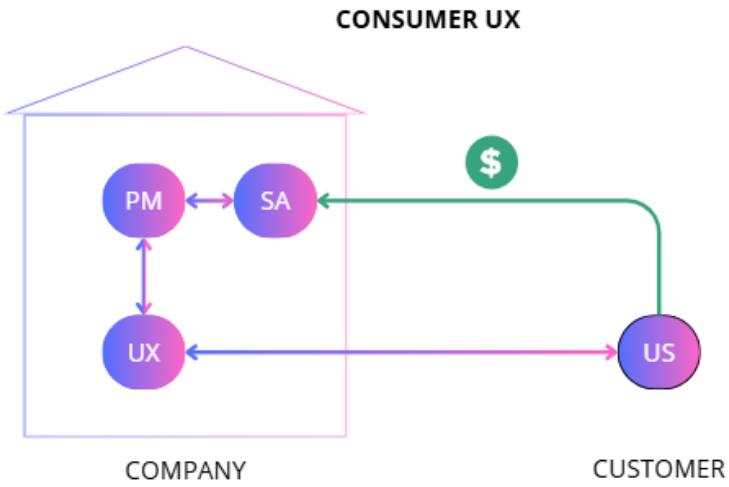


***Figure 3**. Consumer UX: Direct Customer–User Overlap and Profitability Link. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

Note. Conceptual model created by the author. In consumer contexts, the customer is typically the same person as the user, which creates a direct link between UX performance and profitability. Abbreviations: UX = UXer; PM = Product Manager; SA = Sales; US = User.

area for improvement, arguing as early as 2021 that enterprise software design is often worse than consumer-oriented software (Jakob Nielsen [NN/g], 2021). He attributes part of the problem to the persistent misconception that designers "just make things pretty," and he anticipates increasing emphasis on enterprise software that improves productivity rather than merely streamlining physical workflows, since knowledge

workers generate much of the value and rely on these systems. He also points to a growing need for collaboration tools and for software that presents large volumes of data in usable ways (Jakob Nielsen [NN/g], 2021).

The connection between Enterprise UX and profitability is, however, more difficult to demonstrate to stakeholders than in Consumer UX. ROI is always a forecast and cannot be exact because of many changing factors, yet it remains one of the most effective ways to secure buy-in from business-oriented stakeholders (Moran, 2024). This linkage is often weakest in Internal Enterprise UX, where the "customer" is invisible to the market. In this thesis, I distinguish two kinds of Enterprise UX whose relation to profitability differs (**see Figure 4**). In External Enterprise UX (B2B), the revenue stream does not flow as directly through the UX function as it does in Consumer UX. Instead, it typically passes through Sales (SA) and a manager in the client organization who controls budget (MA). Even so, the future end users (US) under that manager can

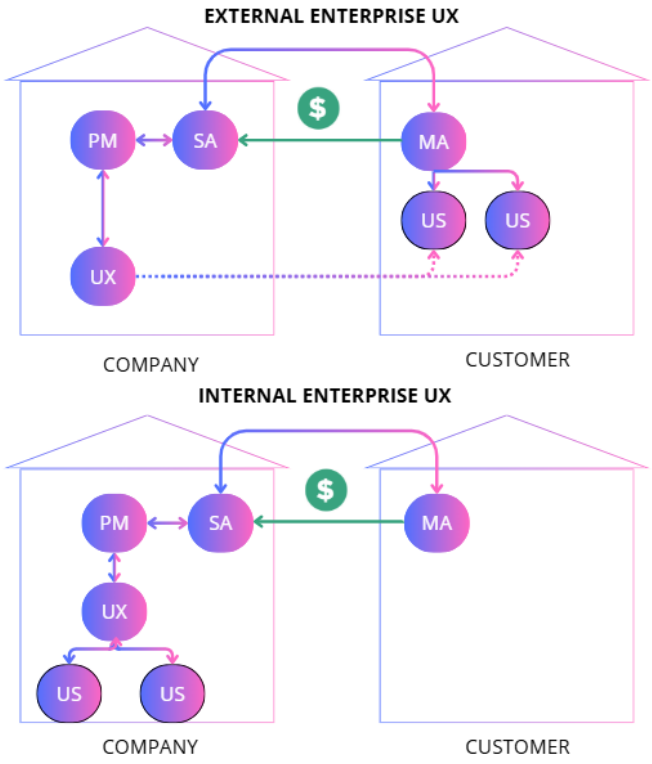


Figure 4. *Enterprise UX: Internal vs. External Paths to Profitability. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author.*

Note. Conceptual model created by the author. Abbreviations: UX = UXer; US = User; SA = Sales; PM = Product Manager; MA = Customer Manager/Approver.

influence purchasing decisions when an intuitive interface and a credible user experience promise clear value, thereby supporting external ROI (Amant et al., 2024).

In Internal Enterprise UX, by contrast, UX influences profitability only indirectly through internal users and their workflows. Metrics therefore tend to be preventative or cost-saving, such as time on task, error reduction, and decreased support calls, sometimes framed as internal ROI (Amant et al., 2024). The implication is that Enterprise UX designers must rely on different metrics than their consumer counterparts and may have a harder time advocating for their work, with fewer readily available resources and benchmarks to draw on.

2.3 Current UX Barriers and UX Strategy

The barriers to effective UX are a frequent topic at conferences and in recent scholarship. Gorichanaz (2025) examined obstacles to human-centered design in workplace settings and reported several counterintuitive findings. For example, advocating for the user can sometimes hinder progress more than explaining the purpose and effectiveness of practices such as rapid prototyping. He also outlines strategies for corporate contexts, including reframing advocacy in terms of the business's benefits, fostering a design culture that emphasizes prototyping's value for the business, and choosing testing methods that most effectively engage the specific stakeholders involved.

To combat these barriers, terms such as Strategic UX and UX strategy have been introduced in business contexts. One of the most influential books on this topic is *UX Strategy* by Jaime Levy (2015). In her explanation of what UX strategy is, she writes:

"The UX strategy makes a case for all touch points and weaves them into a seamless ecosystem between buyer and seller through the UX design. It accounts for the user's entire journey down the funnel." (p. 17). She later adds: "Strategy goes beyond the abstract nature of design and into the land of critical thinking. Critical thinking is disciplined thinking that is clear, rational, open-minded, and informed by evidence. Product stakeholders and entrepreneurs use the critical thinking in a UX strategy to

help them connect the dots among all the points — the customers, their needs, and the solution they all want to solve using technology." (p. 21).

Therefore, UX strategy is closely tied to business impact and requires disciplined reasoning to identify solutions that best satisfy user needs. At the same time, Levy emphasizes collaboration as the principal constraint on any UX strategy:

"UX strategy requires collaboration among team members and stakeholders. It doesn't matter whether you're a student in a classroom, a fledging startup, or a cross-functional team at an enterprise. The tactics don't work unless you all work together." (Levy, 2015, p. 10).

A further point from Gorichanaz (2025) is especially relevant here. Many designers and stakeholders seek more ethical approaches to technology development, yet guidance often centers narrowly on individual UX practitioners, providing theoretical mappings or toolkits that have not yielded widespread organizational change. He suggests the bottleneck may lie "upstream" in organizational culture. His recommendation is to first build a culture of design and intellectual humility that welcomes rethinking and relearning in fast-changing contexts (Gorichanaz, 2025, pp. 19–20). Interpreted for this thesis, designers must be attentive to profitability and business realities to sustain their practice, while organizations need cultures that recognize the value of UX inputs and allow temporary pauses to develop better-considered solutions. Without this cultural groundwork, ethical aspirations and human-centered methods struggle to take root. Furthermore, as Gorichanaz (2025, pp. 17–18) notes,

"Many designers, researchers and other stakeholders today would like to see organizations take a more ethical approach to technology development. Yet guidance to that end has been limited. (...) The existing literature tends to be centered on the agency of UX professionals and includes theoretical contributions (e.g., mapping the complexities of acting ethically) and practical contributions (e.g., toolkits, card decks, activities). If these efforts are not yet resulting in widespread impact, one reason may

be that examining ethics per se is already looking too far downstream (the water is blocked upstream, elsewhere in the organization).”

He proposes that the first step is a cultural shift toward a culture open to design and intellectual humility. There seem to be missing actionable frameworks for UX designers on how to shift design culture, even though they are often the ones most invested in doing so — both because of ideals associated with concepts like Industry 5.0 and because of the practical need to secure their importance in the workplace. To improve influence, and possibly the ethics of proposed products, UX professionals must look upstream to culture and strategy, not only downstream to methods and tools.

2.4 Increasing UX influence in a Corporate

Today, UX maturity is often used to gauge the influence of UX and design within a company. Perhaps the best-known model is the six-level framework from the NN/g

(Pernice et al., 2024; see **Figure 5**). The authors also emphasize that an organization's overall UX maturity is not the same as the maturity of any single team:

"UX-focused leadership and knowledge sharing must happen at the organization-wide level, not just within teams. Thus, true UX maturity should be evaluated for an entire organization rather than for a single team."

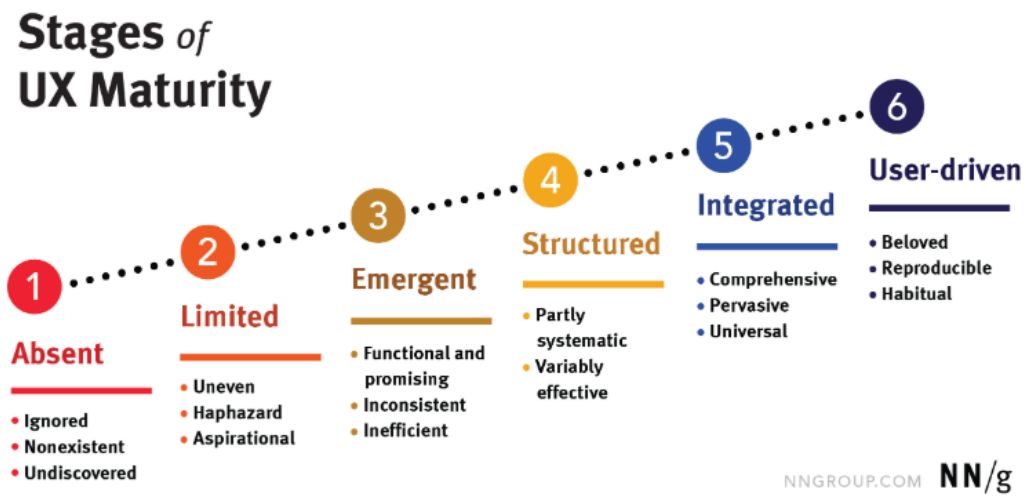


Figure 5. *NN/g UX Maturity Levels (Six Stages). Pernice et al., 2024. Source: https://www.nngroup.com/articles/ux-maturity-model/*

However, for discussing internal influence, I prefer a scheme by Vetrov (2013; see **Figure 6**), because it more directly addresses the level of planning to which UX has access and assumes UX already exists at some level. It also makes it easier for an interviewed UXer to understand how far the company lets them go without extensive study of the NN/g's levels, since it maps cleanly to positions and titles in enterprises. As Vetrov (2013) explains, organizational UX ranges from operational (the designer primarily executes specific tasks and deliverables), to tactical (the designer collaborates integrally within product teams to embed design into broader development processes),

and ultimately to strategic (the designer takes a visionary or leadership role shaping the product's long-term direction and evolution).



Figure 6. Three Levels of UX Maturity. Vetrov, 2013. Source: https://www.uxmatters.com/mt/archives/2013/12/applied-ux-strategy-part-1-maturity-models.php

If UX aims to be more influential in a given company, it needs to act in ways that move toward the strategic level. Although changing design culture can be difficult, it is not impossible. The concept of the Culture Cycle (see Figure 7) describes two complementary pathways for change, grounded in the idea that

"While individuals are shaped by their cultures, they also, in turn, shape those cultures by participating in some aspects of them or resisting others, feeding back into the cycle" (Hamedani et al., 2023, p. 391).

In a corporate setting, top-down change typically flows from top management to employees, while bottom-up change originates with employees, including UXers. Ideally, top management understands the value of UX and champions it through everyday interactions, forming a culture that values design. At other times, because of leadership turnover, shifts in company strategy, or similar events, cultural change must come from UX, bottom-up. To ensure durable change, both directions often need to reinforce one another. As Hamedani et al. (2023) propose,

"one approach that can help with negotiating these top-down/bottom-up tensions is to engage a key changemaker or form a strategic coalition that can work as trusted and

influential ‘bridge builder’ among stakeholders in a community or organization” (p. 392).

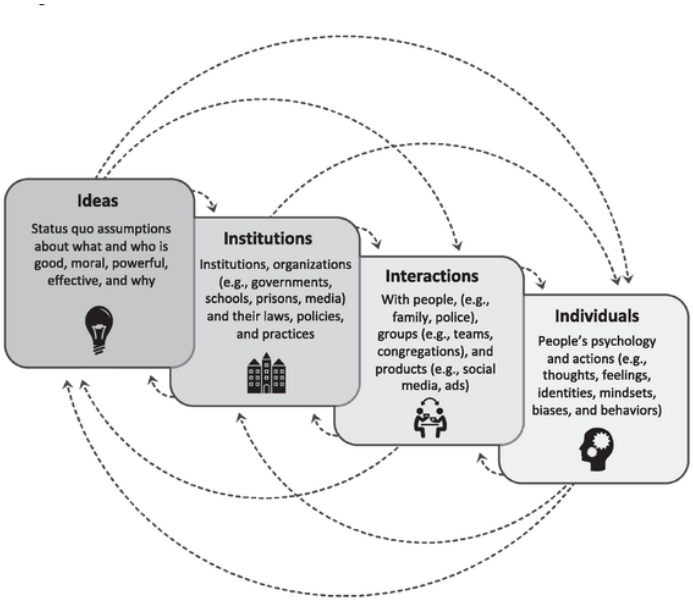


***Figure** 7. The Culture Cycle. The change can be created in two directions – top-down (from left to right) or bottom-up (from right to left). Hamedani et al., 2023. Source: https://doi.org/10.1145/3711008*

For UXers to find such bridge builders within the organization, they need strong persuasion skills — often framed as *stakeholder management* or *user advocacy* — especially in organizations or teams at lower levels of design maturity. As Mambrey et al. (1998, p. 293) note, many factors influence any stakeholder’s decisions at work, including “experiences, attitudes, and career expectations; different research and development orientations; working contexts; goals, tasks, methods, and tools; and political and economical contexts.” UXers themselves also act as stakeholders, so their own decisions are shaped by these factors as well. In Mambrey et al.’s study, designers initially criticized newly introduced user-advocate roles as filtered, and the role created significant conflicts in the team. In the end, designers judged that the benefits outweighed the drawbacks, yet the approach was seen as costly compared to alternative methodologies. Even today, as Kashfi et al. (2016) point out, popular Agile processes can be developer-centered and omit other roles, such as UXers, even though for practitioners grounded in user-centered design it is not feasible to omit the user.

Especially because it is UXers that often find it difficult to do their job properly because of the previously listed reasons in Section 2.3, both cultural pathways to change remain relevant.

2.5 Gaining Stakeholders' Trust

Possibly, it was this distrust from stakeholders toward a channelled point of view that led UX to evolve into the more quantitative role it appears to be today. For UX to prove itself, it may now need to argue its case more forcefully and align more explicitly with business goals, which can run against the broad, systemic view of UX initially imagined by Don Norman (Merholz, 1998). The challenge of putting a number on something as elusive as human experience, and deciding to what extent it should be quantified, seems to be among the greatest day-to-day hurdles in contemporary practice. Yet if UX wants to keep its relevance and influence over new technologies such as AI, some degree of quantification appears necessary. Even OpenAI's ChatGPT 5.0 seemed to misunderstand its users: despite announcing a shift toward a design mindset through a merger with Products, Inc. earlier this year (Altman & Ive, 2025), users complained so intensely about its sudden insensitivity that the previous 4.0 version had to be reinstated (Freedman, 2025). This suggests that, even if the user's voice is muted inside some companies, it can still be loud enough in public to force change. However, that is clearly a Consumer UX case; Enterprise UX users are unlikely to be heard at the same volume. In enterprise settings, concerns may fail to travel far enough inside the organization, may not be framed as materially important, may resist easy quantification, or may surface ethical questions about emerging parasocial relationships with AI. These remain informed speculations.

Contrary to these broad human experiences, feelings, and expectations, Lachner et al. (2016, p. 2) argue that:

"It is inevitable for a practically oriented UX evaluation and communication process in interdisciplinary teams to narrow down the broad scope of UX to a quantifiable level."

Their expert interviews also illustrate how broadly UX collaborates across functions. Respondents most often named Backend Development (83%), followed by Visual/Graphics Design and Marketing (each 75%). Interaction Design and Product Management were each cited by 50%, User Research by 42%, and Usability Engineering/Testing, UI/Frontend Development, and General Management by 21% each; Public Relations appeared at 13%. One pattern worth noting is the relatively high collaboration with Marketing (75%), which tentatively suggests that many respondents were working on consumer-facing products; however, because the study does not report a sector breakdown, this inference should be treated with caution (Lachner et al., 2016, Table 5). Two practical implications follow: first, the collaboration center of gravity skews toward technical and business-facing partners, which means UXers must

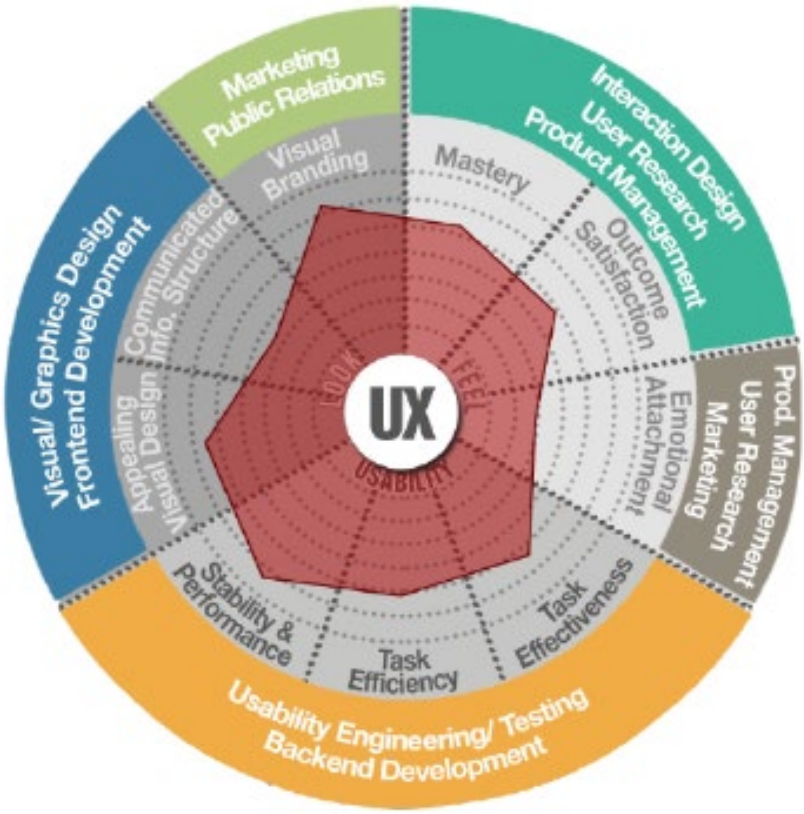


Figure 8 *Their proposed tools for UXers Lachner et al., 2016. Source: https://doi.org/10.1145/2971485.2971501*

translate insights into both implementation terms and market terms; second, executive-adjacent roles are not rare in UX collaboration, reinforcing the need for communication that scales from detailed evidence to concise, decision-ready summaries. Solving a similar issue, the team proposed a visualization tool to align stakeholders' perspectives on a product's UX by collecting feedback through surveys (see Figure 8). The authors report that this tool was successful in practice, but there still appeared to be a need for deeper insight from the stakeholder's point of view.

Stakeholders wanted to know how to act on the numbers, asking, in effect, What *can I do about it?* As one interviewee put it: "It would be really helpful if you could provide us with some additional, qualitative tools to analyze our weak spots in more detail." (Lachner et al., 2016, p. 7). In other words, one type of information is not enough without the other; stakeholders still need both quantitative indicators and qualitative explanations to understand how to address identified issues.

Even though UXers may feel pressure to adopt more *factual* and *numbered* approaches for data-oriented stakeholders, the findings of Coutts et al. (2018) complicate that impulse. They show that prosocial and emotional negotiation strategies can produce more effective joint outcomes than purely rational approaches, yet participating designers still found these strategies difficult to enact in practice. Part of the difficulty stems from the perception that emotional reasoning is less legitimate in professional and technical settings, which helps explain why designers often feel compelled to argue with numbers to be taken seriously. This creates a paradox: while emotionally attuned negotiation can strengthen collaboration, designers hesitate to use it because it risks undermining their credibility, as they are already seen as the *creatives* or *emotional*, even though retaining this side can be beneficial.

Failing such negotiations repeatedly can also trigger learned helplessness. Martinko and Gardner (1982) explain it as: "the notion that after repeated punishment or failure, persons become passive and remain so even after environmental changes that make success possible." (p. 196) This lens may help explain why a significant number of practitioners seem to be leaving UX roles: wearing multiple hats, spending most of their

time negotiating rather than designing, and, above all, engaging in more self-promotion than engineers or peers from other backgrounds (Ari Pxl, 2024). time negotiating rather than designing, and, above all, engaging in more self-promotion than engineers or peers from other backgrounds (Ari Pxl, 2024).

2.6 Visual Tools as Power Switchers

What Lachner et al. (2016) demonstrate, and what appears to work in practice, is that visualisation mainly functions as a catalyst for conversation and reflection. Visual artefacts are not powerful because of their precision or aesthetic quality alone; rather, they create a shared reference point that allows different stakeholders to step outside their immediate perspective. Such artefacts likely exhibit several of the characteristics identified by Glegg (2018) and therefore represent data, enable dialogue, and help effect change. They allow information to be seen, questioned, and reinterpreted in ways that text or numbers alone often do not. In this sense, a visual tool can prompt people to think differently, to shift their point of view through discussion, and to experience what Brinkmann (2014) calls a first “stumbling” moment in an otherwise unshakeable reality. In those moments of disruption, tacit or unarticulated knowledge can surface, offering access to insights that might otherwise remain hidden. Glegg (2018) refers to such artefacts as visual tools, which can help address persistent challenges in qualitative research, such as eliciting higher quality data and supporting participants in articulating thoughts and tacit understandings that are difficult to verbalize.

However, the potential of these tools is contingent on context. They tend to be most effective when colleagues are willing to listen, to recognise UX’s role and importance, and to trust that improving user experience will not make their own work harder (Amant et al., 2024). If those conditions are absent — if stakeholders see UX as a distraction, a threat, or an unnecessary burden — then even the most carefully designed visual artefact risks being ignored or dismissed. Moreover, the tool developed by Lachner et al. (2016) appears oriented toward consumer contexts, where marketing departments play a strong role in shaping and interpreting user insights. This orientation limits its direct applicability to Enterprise UX, where the emphasis is on

internal products, cross-functional alignment, and long-term organizational efficiency rather than market-facing persuasion.

This brings us back to the distinction between Enterprise UX and Consumer UX. The two domains operate with different metrics, stakeholder groups, and definitions of success. Consumer UX often centers on adoption, conversion, and retention, while Enterprise UX deals with productivity, error reduction, compliance, and long-term maintainability. Yet both rely on one common factor: stakeholders' trust. Whether the audience is a marketing team in a consumer setting or a sales or operations team in an enterprise setting, designers need others to believe in the value of the work, to engage with findings, and to allocate resources. Much has been written about involving stakeholders early in the design process, but far less has been said about the step before that: how to secure initial motivation, how to encourage stakeholders to participate at all, and how to convince them that engaging with research is worth their time. This is especially acute in the context of internal enterprise software, where the end users are employees and the benefits of UX are less visible in revenue terms. As Gorichanaz (2025) notes, this perspective is rarely explored directly from the UX practitioner's point of view.

At this point, the work of UX becomes less about methods and more about negotiation and ally-building across the organization. Influence depends on identifying potential bridge builders who can amplify UX and raise design maturity. These bridge builders may hold formal authority, but more often they operate through informal power. Power, as Mosleh and Larsen (2020) argue with reference to Norbert Elias, is emergent from relations and interdependencies rather than a fixed attribute of a single person. In this relational view, everyone in an organization has some degree of power, which ebbs and flows depending on how they connect to others. A useful way to interpret this is to consider power as linked to the ability to build relationships and to be relatable in terms of work practices, organizational culture, or shared understanding. For UX designers, this is often a hurdle, since their role has historically been misunderstood or

marginalized. As Merholz (1998) already pointed out when the term “user experience” was still young, the discipline has long been perceived as secondary, concerned with surface appearance rather than strategic outcomes.

Mosleh and Larsen’s (2020) ethnographic case shows how informal power can shape projects in practice. In their example, an external researcher became a consequential figure simply because their work was seen as crucial by two competing managers. The managers’ ambitions elevated the researcher into a position of influence that exceeded their formal mandate. While the situation raised ethical concerns and was not entirely comfortable for the researcher, it demonstrates that design and research roles can, under certain conditions, become central to corporate dynamics. In other words, influence is not fixed; it can expand rapidly when others view UX as instrumental to their own goals.

Once a designer is perceived as a strategic partner who helps others succeed, they are more likely to be invited into key conversations, to demonstrate what UX can do, and to assemble wider support for UX tactics. Levy (2015) stresses that this transformation depends on moving beyond the idea of UX as a support service and positioning it as a partner in problem-solving. Achieving this requires not only methodological competence but also a strong grasp of stakeholder motivations (Mambrey et al., 1998) and an ability to present insights in ways that resonate with different audiences (Coutts et al., 2018). Designers who tailor their evidence to the expectations of each forum — metrics for finance, narratives for product, prototypes for engineering — demonstrate relevance in a language others understand.

Building organizational importance through consistent and visible contributions is equally important. Amant et al. (2024) underline that management, in particular, must be convinced of research’s positive effects. Executives do not simply grant UX authority because of methodological rigor; they need to see evidence of impact on business outcomes, whether that means smoother rollouts, reduced training costs, or fewer customer complaints. The accumulation of such visible wins can gradually reposition UX as a source of organizational value rather than an optional add-on.

If these efforts fail, however — if designers cannot secure allies, cannot demonstrate strategic relevance, and cannot shift perceptions — the risk is that individuals slide into learned helplessness. As Martinko and Gardner (1982) describe, this occurs when repeated setbacks condition people to stop trying, even when opportunities for success later appear. For UX designers, this means disengaging from advocacy, avoiding confrontation, or narrowing their role to the safe but limited work of surface design. The organization loses potential value, and the individual risks burnout or exit. Recognizing this danger underscores why negotiation, ally-building, and visible impact are not just desirable strategies, but necessary for sustaining UX influence in enterprise settings.at Lachner et al. (2016) demonstrate, and what appears to work in practice, is that visualisation mainly functions as a catalyst for conversation and reflection. Such artefacts likely exhibit several of the characteristics identified by Glegg (2018) and therefore represent data, enable dialogue, and help effect change. In this sense, a visual tool can prompt people to think differently, to shift their point of view through discussion, and to experience a first “stumbling” moment (Brinkmann, 2014) in an otherwise unshakeable reality, allowing tacit or unarticulated knowledge to surface. Glegg (2018) refers to these as visual tools, which can ease persistent challenges in qualitative research, such as eliciting higher quality data and supporting the articulation of participants’ thoughts and tacit knowledge.

H However, these tools tend to be most effective when colleagues are willing to listen, to recognise UX’s role and importance, and to understand that improving UX will not make their own work harder (Amant et al., 2024). At the same time, the tool developed by Lachner et al. (2016) seems oriented toward consumer contexts, at least judging from the high involvement of Marketing, which limits its direct applicability to UX work on internal products. This returns us to the distinction between Enterprise UX and Consumer UX: they do not use the same metrics, they need not appeal to the same stakeholders, yet both rely on stakeholders’ trust to secure cooperation. While much has been written about involving stakeholders early, far less addresses the step before that: how to motivate stakeholders to participate at all, to engage with findings, and to

allocate resources to research, especially for internal enterprise software, from the UXer's point of view (cf. Gorichanaz, 2025).

At that point, the work becomes primarily about negotiation and ally-building across the organisation, identifying potential bridge builders who can raise design maturity. Bridge builders hold formal or, more often, informal power. Power can be viewed in many ways, but within the informal sphere, Mosleh and Larsen (2020) draw on Norbert Elias to frame power as emergent from relations and interdependencies. On this view, everyone in a company possesses varying degrees of power depending on how they relate to others. If we add a bit of word play, it could transfer to how they build *relationships*, and how *relatable* they are in terms of work, place, and shared understanding. This can be a hurdle for UX designers, whose role has often been misunderstood since the term was coined (Merholz, 1998).

Mosleh and Larsen (2020) also present an ethnographic case showing how such informal power can arise and shape a project. Although the researcher was external, the importance of their work made the researcher a powerful figure in the ambitions of two competing managers, which complicates some of the assumptions outlined earlier. The situation raises ethical questions and was not entirely comfortable for the researcher, yet it illustrates that designers and researchers can occupy consequential roles in corporate settings.

Once a designer is perceived as a strategic partner who helps others achieve their goals, they are more likely to gain the chance to demonstrate what UX can do, to assemble support for UX tactics, and to collaborate effectively (Levy, 2015). Achieving this requires a strong grasp of stakeholder motivations (Mambrey et al., 1998) and of how to present insights to different audiences (Coutts et al., 2018). Building organisational importance through visible, valuable contributions beyond the immediate product team is likewise underscored by Amant et al. (2024), who note that management in particular must be convinced of research's positive effects.

If these tactics repeatedly fail, and designers cannot secure allies or strategic relevance, learned helplessness may result, with individuals becoming passive after repeated setbacks despite later opportunities for success (Martinko & Gardner, 1982).

3 The Process

This thesis, from its unexpected beginnings, was guided by an abductive approach which, compared to data-driven or theory-driven approaches, is best described as breakdown-driven. Abduction does not follow a straight line from hypothesis to confirmation, nor does it rest entirely on the accumulation of data. Instead, it begins with disruptions. It follows Brinkmann's (2014) "stumble-upon" path of gathering insights from surprising, unplanned, and sometimes uncomfortable moments. These moments can occur in conversations, while reading, or even in ordinary practice, when something does not fit existing assumptions and forces a pause. That pause, or "stumbling," is the spark that opens curiosity and makes it necessary to look again, to reframe, and to seek a new perspective. In this way, the surprising moments themselves become the data. First, a situation unsettles the prevailing way of seeing; then, through inquiry and reflection, the researcher works to regain balance by reframing their understanding (Brinkmann, 2014).

Adopting this abductive stance meant that my project unfolded more like a dialogue than a plan. Each encounter, whether with participants, academic literature, or organizational realities, carried the potential to shift direction. Rather than treating such shifts as distractions, the approach acknowledged them as part of the knowledge-making process. Unexpected obstacles — for instance, stakeholders not engaging in ways I had anticipated, or insights emerging in offhand remarks rather than formal sessions — became productive rather than problematic. These breakdowns, while initially disorienting, were precisely the sites where new understanding emerged.

Building on Bailey et al.'s (2019) work on transforming wicked problems (Skaburskis, 2008) into actionable briefs through design-led methods, the abductive path of this project can still be mapped in broad terms to the Double Diamond model (Design Council, n.d.). The project moved through a rhythm of diverging and converging: opening up to explore unexpected findings, then narrowing down to frame them into concrete directions. Yet a closer fit is found in Sanders and Stappers' (2014) view of the Co-design process (see Figure 9). Their model places strong emphasis on the early

phases of exploration and generation, where designers work alongside others to uncover needs, articulate challenges, and imagine possible futures. My work concentrated heavily on these pre-design and generative phases and concluded near the start of prototyping, intentionally leaving product-level development open-ended. This was a deliberate choice, as the focus was less on delivering a polished solution and more on making visible the dynamics, struggles, and influence points that shape Enterprise UX.

Throughout, the research has remained anchored in the world as it is, while keeping a careful eye toward the near future. This meant attending closely to participants' present experiences — their coping methods, their everyday strategies, and their stories of constraint and possibility. By staying grounded in these realities, potential design interventions could be imagined not as abstract ideals, but as responses to lived struggles. The goal, in line with Sanders and Stappers (2014), was not to "solve" the problem in a final sense, but to provide generative insights and designable supports that could open paths forward, adaptable to different organizational contexts. In this

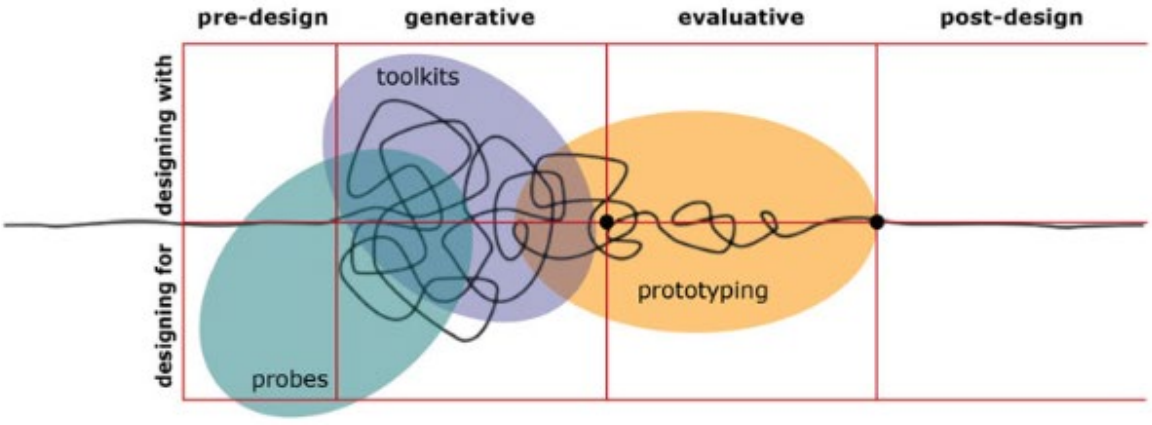


Figure 9. *Design Phases Framework by Sanders and Stappers. Sanders and Stappers, 2014. Source: https://doi.org/10.1080/15710882.2014.888183*

way, the abductive journey of this thesis sought to honor the complexity of the field while still pointing toward actionable futures.

3.1 Research Phases

Working from this philosophy, the project unfolded across several phases between February 2025 (official start) and September 2025, with early ideas about outcomes evolving as new perspectives and conversations emerged. In the initial stage, I encountered “stumble-upon” moments (Brinkmann, 2014) that were not intended as thesis material at first but gradually became part of the inquiry. I label this Phase 0, a pre-project period in late January and early February 2025 that seeded the direction of the work.

The first diamond opened in Phase 1 (February–April 2025), when I began the literature review and designed interviews with Enterprise UX experts. Phase 2 (April–May 2025) combined these expert interviews with exploratory design probes and an additional interview with an engineer-turned-UX practitioner focused on Industry 5.0, which helped situate the topic within broader technological and organisational shifts. Phase 3 brought additional participant (May 2025). In Phase 4 (May–June 2025), I conducted a detailed thematic analysis to consolidate insights and formally close the first diamond. Phase 5 (July 2025) involved prototyping and exploring possible design responses; this opened the second diamond and translated analytical themes into candidate interventions. Finally, in Phase 6 (August 2025), I discussed these prototypes with two of the earlier participants to gather targeted feedback, which informed refinements and closed the second diamond.

Further procedural specifics (participant characteristics, recruitment and consent, recording/transcription and anonymisation, analytic steps, and artefacts produced per phase) are added in later sections of the thesis and the appendices.

3.1.1 Phase 0: Probes and Empirical Data Gathering

This phase is characterised by stumble-upon data in Brinkmann's (2014) sense. It grew largely out of my internship experiences. I spent several months under the direct management of one eventual participant; I visited another participant's offices; and a third mentored a student group I belonged to for half a year. These connections allowed me to see, hear, and experience some of the struggles of Enterprise UX first-hand. Over time, I began noticing the same issues discussed more broadly on LinkedIn (Chan, 2022), on the Nielsen Norman Group site (Moran et al., 2025), and at the UX Nordic Conference 2024 (Official Agenda of the UX Nordic Conference 2024, n.d.). Although not formally part of my intended research design, these encounters sensitised me to how UX professionals are increasingly expected to work with quantitative metrics, to manage stakeholders carefully, and to frame outcomes in ways that are legible to the business.

Around this time, I also realised that many of my prior assumptions were consumer-centric. By contrast, both my internship and these practitioners' accounts emphasised data, numbers, and making outcomes valuable in the eyes of stakeholders. On social media, a growing pessimism about the post-COVID UX job market echoed my own observations (as introduced earlier). I had personally encountered stakeholders' limited interest in research during a project, and I witnessed a significant downturn in design and research roles, including one brand eliminating its only UX position. The questions that set this thesis in motion were: "Why would a company let go the only person that knows the portfolio of all these high-tech products and its history of developing from the user perspective while the sister company still has a team? Why are many of the expensively generated insights forgotten about or lost somewhere in the process? And where does it happen?" These experiences, together with noticing how much networking and extra work seemed necessary to earn respect as a designer, sparked my curiosity about the internal status of Enterprise UX, its perceived value, and, most importantly, what can be done about it.

3.1.2 Phase 1: Preparing Interviews and Designing Tool for Conversation

Quite early on, I realised this topic could branch in many directions, and that I would not be able to present a single general solution for every designer in every company. It is a wicked problem (Skaburskis, 2008): not solvable in a straightforward way, but approachable by addressing a small, tractable part of a larger, complex whole. I therefore narrowed the scope to deeply understanding selected professionals' day-to-day experiences and to identifying where—and in whom—they perceive the issues to sit, as well as what might be designed to support Enterprise UXers' internal position.

Guided by my own experience and an admittedly cautious outlook at the time, I prioritised participants with Enterprise UX experience in Denmark. I focused on engineering-heavy, high-tech contexts (e.g., robotics) where, from my perspective, there was a higher likelihood of tension between "engineering" and "design," and of distrust toward the value of UX research. I wanted practitioners to speak candidly about how UX actually works in their company: how insights are generated, where they travel (or stall) in the organisation, and where they are ignored, diluted, or lost. Because participants were located across Denmark, I planned online interviews. Given the potentially sensitive nature of the topic, and to elicit frank accounts, I conducted anonymous, individual interviews.

To help interviewees recall and reflect on the full range of stakeholders they collaborate with, I designed an interactive visual tool (Glegg, 2018). Its purpose was twofold: (1) to support recall through visualisation and (2) to situate stakeholders relationally from the designer's point of view. I adapted an egocentric mapping approach, informed by RACI-style maps (Suhanda & Pratami, 2021; "RACI Stakeholder Whiteboard Map – Venngage," n.d.) and by egocentric network mapping in ethnographic research (e.g., Nadoh et al., 2004), which places the interviewee at the centre.

The final map used four concentric layers (from the centre outward): *Closest Collaborators I Need to Influence*, *Close Collaborators I Need to Influence*, *Further Collaborators I Need to Influence*, and *Furthest Collaborators I Need to Influence*.

Stakeholders were added on colour-coded post-its: green for “easy to influence,” yellow for “neutral,” and red for “hard to influence.” To capture sentiment and criticality, interviewees could add stickers: a thumbs-down for “This person does not see the value in my design, we clash,” a thumbs-up for “This person is very important to have on my side, otherwise the project does not pass,” and a heart for “This person is on my side helping me influence others.” The aim was to surface where in the organisation influence tends to falter or flow, and how this differs across participants. In practice, interviewees often modified the scheme when needed—for example, one participant (P3) introduced pink post-its to denote “Impossible to influence,” and some varied sticker size to reflect intensity of sentiment.

I Initially, interviewees were meant to manipulate the Figma board themselves. Considering interview length and tool familiarity, I instead operated the map while interviewees verbalised their placement decisions. This reduced friction, encouraged richer explanation (“why this person here?”), and kept the conversation focused. No participant was shown any other participant’s map. As part of recruitment, invitees were informed of the general topics and told that a mapping exercise would be included.

Alongside the mapping, I prepared a semi-structured interview guide (see Attachments). The aims were to document current negotiation practices, the extent of additional labour (e.g., stakeholder management, internal advocacy), and, crucially, to trace where and why user insights fail to reach implementation or are de-prioritised. I was also interested in whether design interventions could help drive change, rather than defaulting to prescriptions that simply ask engineers or other roles to “be more accepting,” which is a common stance in the literature (e.g., De Vere & Melles, 2010).

3.1.3 Phase 2: Expert interviews and ego-centric mapping with Enterprise UXers

Therefore, four long-term, practising Enterprise UX professionals were selected for a first round of one-hour, semi-structured interviews. Participants were recruited through personal connections established in Phase 0 and via outreach to a LinkedIn

group in the local UX Collective. Inclusion criteria were: a minimum of 3 years' Enterprise UX experience in a large, tech-heavy or industrial company, and regular cross-functional collaboration with engineering teams. This profile increased the likelihood of encountering settings where tensions between engineering and design might arise, which aligned with this thesis's aims:

- **Participant 1 (P1):** 10+ years in user-experience roles, including team leadership; currently Head of UX & Product Design (Senior Manager) in a robotics B2B company with more than one thousand employees, covering both physical products and the software used to operate robots as part of the overall CX. Her focus is primarily External Enterprise UX, with some Internal Enterprise UX for engineers working with the robots.
- **Participant 2 (P2)**: 4+ years as a UX designer working mostly as a solo practitioner, with a PhD in human–computer interaction, in a B2B electronics-manufacturing company of over four thousand employees. His work is largely in External Enterprise UX.
- **Participant 3 (P3):** 9+ years of UX-related experience across managerial and entrepreneurial roles; reflects on a tenure within a robotics B2B company of more than four hundred employees embedded in a larger global ecosystem (different from P1's setting). He served as the only UX designer across both the robots' physical aspects and their software. The role was mainly External Enterprise UX, though, as in P1's case, it also involved internal use.
- **Participant 4 (P4)**: UX Designer with 6+ years in the field; part of a larger UX team in a company with over one hundred thousand employees worldwide. She currently designs purely internal tools, i.e., Internal Enterprise UX, in a major logistics company, where she has worked for two and a half years.

The interviews were in English and semi-structured to adapt to each participant's reality while ensuring comparable coverage across cases. Each session was conducted as a recorded online video call with cameras on for both parties and was planned for

approximately one hour. In addition to the questions, each interview included an ego-centric stakeholder-mapping exercise in Figma (See **Figure 10**) to surface the participant's internal network, influence zones, and perceived ease or difficulty of persuading different roles. Interviews were conducted during the end of April 2025.

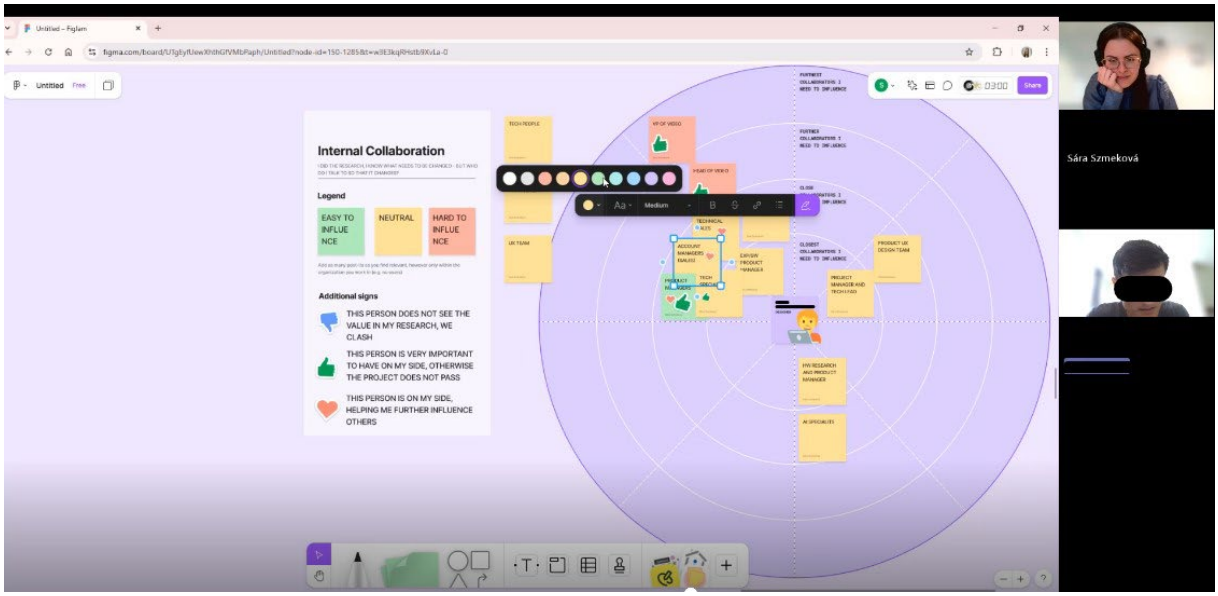


Figure 10. *A screenshot from the mapping activity with one of the interviewees. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

3.1.4 Phase 3: Engineer turned UX Designer Interview

Within the pool of people willing to participate, I also interviewed **P5**, a UX researcher with an engineering bachelor's degree and a design-focused master's degree. P5 works in a vocational education and training institution and is one of the leaders and founding members of a local UX community, regularly hearing experiences from practicing UXers in the region as well as from students preparing for careers in factories and similarly industrial settings. Although P5 did not fit the primary Enterprise UX inclusion criteria, this profile offered a valuable bridge perspective on topics closely tied to this thesis, especially Industry 5.0 and the relationship between engineering and design in organizational practice. I therefore treated P5 as a key informant to enrich theoretical sensitivity and contextual understanding. The interview followed a semi-structured format similar to the previous sessions but, instead of the mapping activity, focused on Denmark's approach to Industry 5.0 and the lived perspective of someone positioned between the "engineering" and "design" viewpoints. The session was conducted online, recorded with consent, and transcribed for analysis (see **Figure 11**).

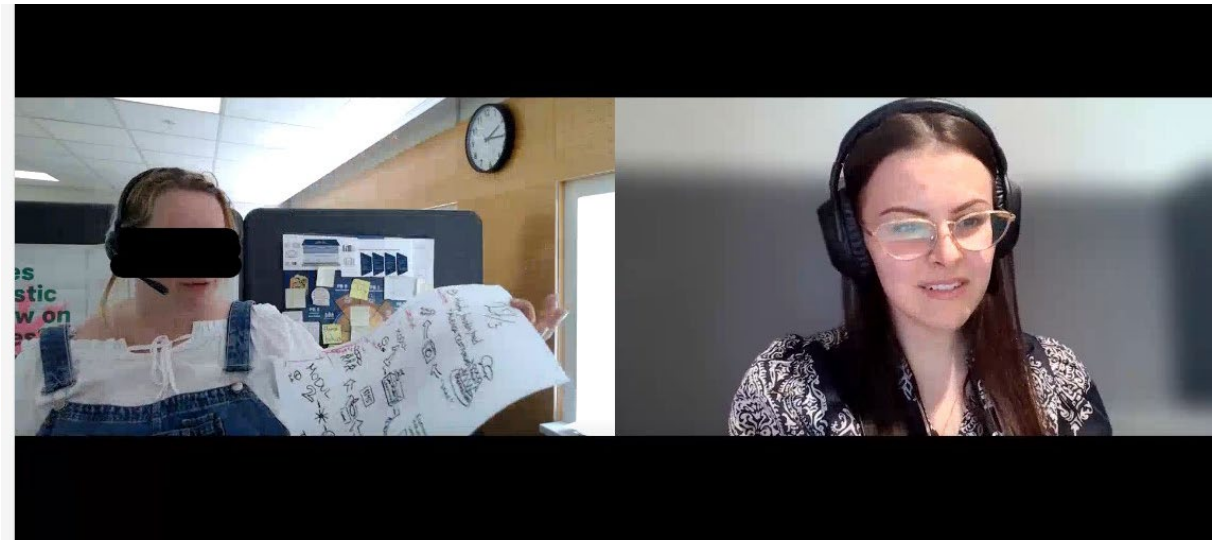


Figure 11 *A screenshot from the interviewee. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

3.1.5 Phase 4: Thematic Analysis and Sense-making

After conducting all five interviews, I transcribed them and organized the material in a private Figma board for analysis. For transparency and to keep voices distinct while clustering, I assigned each participant a unique color used only as an internal visual identifier. All excerpts and notes retained their participant colour during analysis to avoid mixing voices. In the thesis, however, I refer to participants as P1–P5; the colour legend is deliberately not published to preserve anonymity.

I then carried out a thematic analysis according to the Braun and Clarke (2006), coding meaningful excerpts and grouping them into candidate categories. The coding was hybrid: some codes were deductive and mirrored the interview guide, while others emerged inductively from the data. I lightly standardized quotations for readability while keeping the original meaning intact. The resulting themes structure Chapter 4 (Findings) and informed the design opportunities discussed later.

In parallel, I compared the individual ego-centric stakeholder maps (see *Appendices*) to spot convergences and divergences. I focused in particular on potential bridge builders in the second and third rings — people not in daily contact with UX but still close enough to influence outcomes — and on the colour markings that indicated who was easy, neutral, or hard to influence. I also noted areas where repeated difficulty might signal the onset of learned helplessness as described by Martinko and Gardner (1982). This combined reading of transcripts and maps helped surface the main challenge outlined in *Section 4.5*.

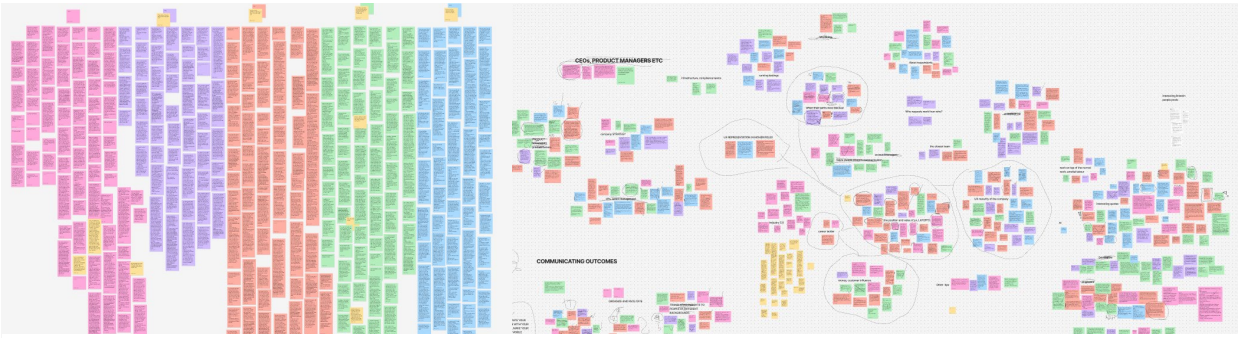


Figure 12. *Insights before and after the thematic analysis in Figma. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

3.1.6 Phase 5: Designing and Experimenting

As a design opportunity was established (Sanders & Stappers, 2014), I developed a first prototype. Rather than a finished proposal, it was a probe to surface possibilities and blind spots. Following Wensveen and Matthews (2014), I treated the prototype both as a research archetype, giving form to my current understanding of the problem, and as a means of inquiry, inviting participants to challenge its usefulness: Was it the right direction, or could the insights be structured differently? By presenting something *physicalized*, even in an online format, I aimed to elicit richer feedback.

Before sharing the prototype, I sketched extensively, exploring angles that later proved to be dead ends or impractical in a corporate context, based on my ethnographic observations. Because the thesis seeks to generate knowledge rather than deliver a finished product, the prototype functions as an early waypoint in the process described by Sanders and Stappers (2014) and as the closing of the second diamond in the Design Council (n.d.) model, just before it opens again. This phase is explained in detail in Chapter 7.

3.1.7 Phase 6: The Prototype Presentation

Therefore, the final part of this project was to gather additional insights and reflections from the original interviewees, which in the end narrowed to two participants — P1 and P4. Both follow-up sessions were conducted online, recorded, and lasted around 30

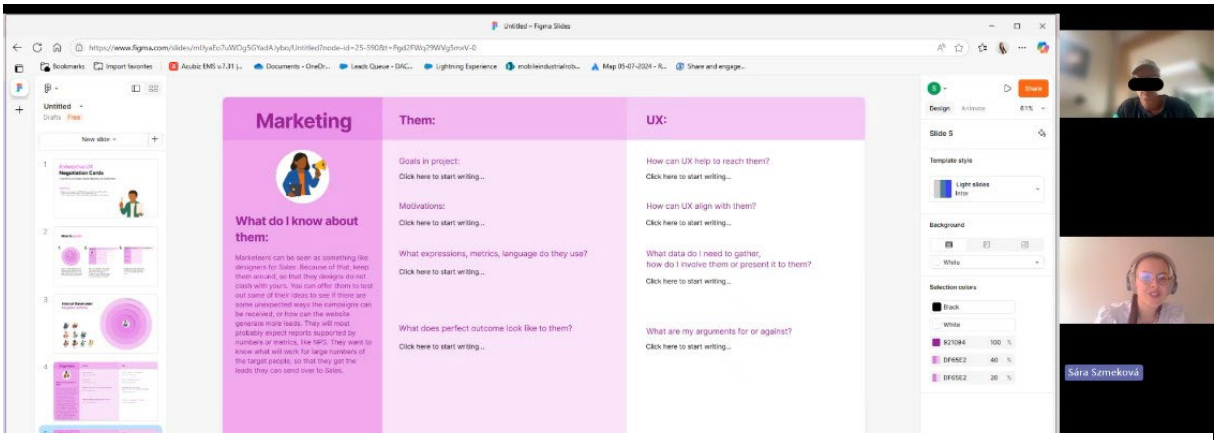


Figure 13. *A screenshot from showing one of the participants the prototype. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

minutes each. Apart from a brief walkthrough of the prototype (**Figure 13**), the conversations were intentionally unscripted to capture first-contact reactions and to prioritize a collaborative ideation format over presenting a finished outcome. The goal was to elicit spontaneous impressions, co-creative critique, and suggestions for reframing or extending the concept. The perspectives emerging from these sessions are presented later in the *Section 5.1.1*.

3.2 Ethical Considerations

As Some interviewees were people I already knew through prior collaboration. I recognize that this could shape what they chose to share and how I interpreted it. To mitigate this, I used a consistent semi-structured guide, kept reflexive notes about my assumptions, and treated any prior knowledge as data only when participants explicitly restated it during the interview.

Before each session, I explained the study purpose, the voluntary nature of participation, and that they could skip questions or stop at any time. I obtained verbal informed consent to record. All identifying details (people, companies, products) were removed or generalized; participants are referenced as P1–P5. Audio files, transcripts, and maps were stored in a private Figma file and computer with a date set to automatically delete itself after the project is finalized. I avoided soliciting confidential or proprietary information and excluded any details that could reasonably identify a person or organization. I followed common research-ethics principles of consent, confidentiality, data minimization, and non-maleficence.

3.3 Strengths and Limitations

One strength of the chosen approach is that anonymity, plus the fact that participants knew of one another only in broad professional terms, enabled unusually frank accounts of their perceived influence and day-to-day tactics. Online, recorded interviews created a comfortable setting and flexible scheduling for designers across Denmark. This yielded rich insight from Enterprise UXers in both managerial and non-

managerial roles, including those embedded in teams and those operating as sole practitioners, each from a different company.

A key limitation is the small sample and the single-perspective lens: findings reflect UXers' accounts and are not corroborated by engineers, product managers, or executives. Inviting multiple roles might have produced uncomfortable dynamics or job risk for participants given the sensitivity of topics discussed, so I prioritized confidentiality. Another limitation is potential selection and survivorship bias: several interviewees are experienced and employed at well-known companies, which may make their strategies appear more effective than they would be elsewhere; similar tactics may not translate into success in other contexts.

The study is also Denmark-specific, which may affect transferability to settings with different labor relations, hierarchy norms, or corporate governance. Finally, there is unrealized potential in convening a co-design workshop among participants; given the sensitivity and confidentiality requirements, I judged one-to-one, anonymized interviews to be the more appropriate method. A group format might have surfaced cross-pollinated strategies and collective sense-making but would have raised re-identification risks.

4 Findings

This chapter presents the analysis from Phase 4 (interview analysis). It summarizes what participants reported about the specifics of their roles, their interactions with other functions, and the tactics they use to overcome what they see as the biggest barriers. These insights later inform the prototyping and design exploration in chapter 5.

4.1 Post-COVID Feelings and Aims Towards the Industry 5.0

Participants described a field that has shifted markedly since the pandemic, and not for the better. As P1 noted: “I was at a conference in Berlin at the start of May and unfortunately a lot of people, nearly more people than the ones who actually had a job, was unemployed there because there has been big layoffs all over Europe and a lot of designers and researchers have lost their job and both due to the economical situation but also due to the introduction of AI. So I would say that there is a big change and there's a big pressure on the on the UX designers.” P4 echoed this pressure, observing a turn toward AI-assisted “vibe coding” that makes companies reconsider in-house design roles: “Our role is no longer pixel pushing, which people tend to say about a lot of big companies, but it's really more about helping. Now you have a five million opportunities and everybody has great ideas. Our value is to narrow it down and bring the actual human being back to this loop,” positioning designers more as problem solvers than stylists (see also Don Norman, 2016; Jakob Nielsen [NNgroup], 2021). Yet this shift can be harder to justify to stakeholders than visible UI outputs, and it raises expectations for metrics such as ROI that often sit across multiple departments..

P1 also called for a return to fundamentals in research practice, while pragmatically embracing new tools: “But if designers start working with AI, then they can also be more effective in their job and then they can be the ones doing the smart thing. (…) Don't be afraid that AI will take over your job. It's the same as when the robot started to come. Don't be afraid that the robot will take over your job. If you embrace the technology and try to use the technology the best way, then you can actually use it to solve bigger

problems. But we all need to change, and the number of jobs will definitely be lower in the future.” This stance balances craft, evidence, and tooling, while acknowledging labour-market realities.

Views on Industry 5.0 were similarly cautious. P5, drawing on work in vocational education and local UX community leadership, suggested Denmark still has distance to travel before Industry 5.0 becomes a practical standard. Differences between small and large firms, and ownership structures across countries, complicate reorganization. At the same time, the push is not only top-down from the European Commission (Industry 5.0, a Transformative Vision for Europe, 2021) but also bottom-up: „In the EU at the moment it is coming, and the users want to be recognized as users. The users are calling on it.“ UX may act as a bridge between these directions by elevating user voices, yet P5 warned of economic constraints: „We have to change how we think about yearly revenue, right? Because as long as our yearly revenue is solely tied up to monetary value, we will have issues doing industry 5.0.“ This resonates with the internal debate around linking UX work to ROI while maintaining a broader human-centered mandate.

4.2 Consumer vs Enterprise UX Stakeholders

„When you do things that everybody's using — if you are making a food ordering application or something — everybody has experience with it. In our case, it's like you have a super specialized software. So not everybody has the first hand experience. But still, you know, people have their own ideas and their opinions, and that's difficult. I mean also for us designers is sometimes difficult to put that aside and see this as pretty, but even though you think this is very pretty, the user wants something that's not as pretty because they need to see the five thousand numbers at the same time,“

pointed out P4. In Enterprise UX, users are domain experts who often prioritize dense information, speed, and reliability over visual polish. In consumer contexts, visual appeal can have a stronger influence on perceived quality and trust, which can shift how design decisions are argued for internally.

„ A related difference is access to users for testing. Consumer-facing studies usually require recruiting external participants, scheduling sessions, and paying incentives. In Enterprise settings, internal users are available and can be involved more frequently, which can accelerate iterations and lower costs. As P4 noted:

„ ... But because we also have internal users, so it's an unlimited resource. Some of them even are in the same office as I am. (...) But then of course, the upside or the downside to that, is that also it can be very comfortable. So you have to be mindful to pick other users as well, so it's not always opinion of the same five people when you build solutions because they are also very good at what they're doing. And yeah, you know, the average user doesn't always know everything.“ This underlines a convenience-sampling risk: decisions can drift toward the needs of a few nearby power users rather than the broader user base.

Internal testing also blurs boundaries between “the product” and “the process.” P4 explained: „It's also like for us it's a bit of a tricky setup because my users are my colleagues and also because the processes they follow sometimes they also come from us, right? I don't think that you have that anywhere else when you don't have the internal users that that sometimes it's also that you want your users to change the way they are working. It's not that you're always adapting to them.“ In such contexts, stakeholder incentives matter; colleagues can consciously or unconsciously lobby for their own agendas, one of several motivations observed for workplace stakeholders (Mambrey et al., 1998)

P3 described how this dynamic can reshape authority over UX decisions: „(...) First of all, let's try to build the best possible version from where we are, but it turned out that it was not possible due to product management not listening to to what I said. Due to sales in the company which in this case, it was the Application Engineers. They basically owned the product. (...) So every UX decision had to be approved by them but then can it be sold? They didn't actually sell, but they did kind of a very specific technical task with our product. And if whatever we built did not help their task, it was discarded.“

Here, “internal customers” can become de facto gatekeepers, especially when their KPIs sit closer to immediate revenue than to long-term usability.

Because Enterprise UX relies heavily on internal users and cross-functional gatekeepers, relationship-building and influence tactics become central to having impact. During the ego-centric mapping exercise, participants surfaced the main groups they collaborate with and described how they approach each group. While not all stakeholders appeared in every map, synthesizing these mentions creates a starting point for lightweight stakeholder personas that reflect roles, typical motivations, and common frictions relevant to Enterprise settings.

4.2.1 Engineers

E Even though Application Engineers are technically users as well, they are on site early in the process and are experts by the nature of their work. Without grounding in ethnographic research, their insights can be skewed toward their own expertise. All of the robotics-related respondents, meaning P1, P3, and P5, mentioned that engineers can develop strong ownership over ideas they have spent a long time developing, and that “killing their darlings” is an especially hard task even when user research suggests otherwise. “ (...) So it just becomes more complicated for the user and then the fun thing is that when we talk to the engineers about that, then they always blame the user. So they say: ‚Aah, the user must take some more training. They must be better educated or something to work with our robots.‘ And like, yeah, that doesn't really make sense because what we are building is a user friendly product that should collaborate with users. And a better way to collaborate is to make it easy for the user,” said P1. She later added about collaborating with engineers: “They not always care about the how things look, they just care about the functionality. Then it becomes a hard part for us to influence, but we are only 15 people here and they are like 300, right? So that it's quite a massive group as well that you need to impact there,” which is a tension older than the job titles for both professions. Although market needs seem to be pushing toward greater mutual understanding, works such as De Vere and Melles (2010) still call for stronger design literacy in engineering education..

From the interviews it seems that many decisions in such companies hinge on organisational structure, which roles and insights are most respected, and the prevailing mindset—what is often referred to as design maturity (Pernice et al., 2024; Vetrov, 2013). As all of the explored companies are on the “tech” side, people with engineering backgrounds tend to climb the career ladder; three out of the four Chief Executive Officers of the companies in question have engineering backgrounds.

However, contrary to my initial assumptions, technically minded colleagues — developers and engineers — did not appear to be the primary blockers of UX according to the respondents. Especially when engineers are involved early and have prior exposure to the benefits of research, disagreements still arise but are manageable. In the mapping exercise, only one interviewee marked engineers with a “small thumbs down,” suggesting they were not a frequent source of conflict. P1 was the only participant who changed engineers to red (hard to influence), which appears connected more to sheer numbers — there are far more engineers than designers — than to engineers being the fundamental reason UX struggles to prevail.

As deeply technical people, engineers were described as needing a clear window into how decisions were made, supported by numbers and quantitative evidence. P3 shared: “It's the technical people who just want to know if they're not wasting all of the time or not. They might be interested in actually getting just the raw data dump and looking at it themselves.”

4.2.2 Developers

Although only P3 and P4 mentioned working directly with developers, they described those collaborations in terms that contrasted with engineers. Developers were colleagues they worked with closely and spoke to daily, so the relationship appeared mutually beneficial. An interesting perspective on developers and technical people in general came from P3: „The more technical a person is, the more they are willing to trust data. So if I show them we did this many tests on these and these people, and this was the result of that, they can see the value. Especially because if they don't — technical people also are not in touch with the customers often — so they just discuss and argue

amongst themselves about things that don’t really matter because we can just ask the actual users. So when we come with these and these findings, it's like the Holy Grail that just helps their life become better. “ In practice, concise evidence and clear research artefacts (brief clips, task metrics, and explicit decision logs) helped align decisions quickly and strengthened developer trust.

4.2.3 Product Management

Product management was described by all respondents as comparatively easy to influence, likely because PMs are close collaborators: three of four participants placed them in the innermost circle and marked them green to indicate ease of influence. Most research requests also originate with PMs: “They play a role in terms of actually making this product also a success and making it pass,” shares P2. P4 echoes this alignment: “My product managers care a lot about the user experience and they are also in daily contact with the user, so it‘s quite a unique case. (...) They also care a lot because they know that they are gonna mess up if they don't have that feature right.”

Still, the partnership is not without friction. As P1 explains, “You always have to fight for the influence there. And yes, you can say that it's easier to not work with the insights or the research that we have generated because then you can just make a decision and then you can just build the product as what you think is right. So it will always be an argument for the designer to make sure that we're actually building with and for the customers, and not for ourselves. And that's one of the biggest struggles that we have as UX designers — to prove that we are adding enough value and that the Product Manager is not equal to the user. And the Product Manager always forgets about that because he has his favourites.”

Effective tactics for PM audiences included clear reports or slide decks that combine metrics and synthesized insights, which the UXer then presents with additional narrative context. PMs sometimes contribute their own inputs as well, as P1 notes: “Actually, the Product Manager has also produced a lot of insights to us because when they go to a customer visit, then they bring back insights that we will have to use in our system as well, so we assure that we are aligned on what we are discussing.”

4.2.4 Marketing

Marketing tends to present a somewhat different dynamic. P3, P1, and P2 identified Marketing as a close collaborator.

„Marketing is somehow the designers of sales," explained P3, noting that they are mostly influenced by Sales' point of view rather than UX: „I'm just thinking if they clash (with UX, author's note), but they really do not. But they often are in a different sphere. So if you don't keep track of what they're doing, you risk them creating the new mascot that that you haven't heard about or a new brand text, voice or whatever."

P1 described a more measurement-focused collaboration, where UX assists Marketing with NPS (Net Promoter Score) tracking and reporting. In that context, the UX work skews toward quantitative rather than qualitative inputs, as these metrics are better known and respected within Marketing collaborators.

4.2.5 Sales and Account Managers

Sales, account managers, and generally people with strong presentation and influencing skills emerged as strategically important partners for UXers, even though they were explicitly mapped by only two respondents — P3 and P2. Notably, these two were also the ones working without a dedicated UX team around them, which may explain why they sought allies outside their discipline, often selecting such colleagues as "bridge builders" (Hamedani et al., 2023). In the same spirit, P5 emphasized that having an ally who is sharp in communication is crucial for UX success.

„Account managers also helps you build closer ties with your customers (...) If you interview them a second time or third time, at one point they share some really good insights with you," P2 explains.

At the same time, their priorities can diverge from how UX designers might frame product value. By definition of the role and reward structures, their primary goal is to sell. In Enterprise UX, where the buyer is not the same person as the user, overall product experience may not be their central concern. As P3 put it: „They are easy to influence if they can see a good deal. So you need to put your head on how do we create

a win-win situation. If you don't come to them with something that they can gain, that they understand is of value, then they are actually impossible to influence. (...) They just want to make the product easier to sell. (...) And often sales are in contact with the customers in a way that makes it easy for them to convince the upper management, and this ability is further strengthened by the natural competencies it requires to be a salesperson. (...) If you can get close to sales, you will have a super powerful ally that really understands how to push an agenda through. (...) They are major players in influencing others, especially product management, other management, and marketing. “

Taken together, these accounts suggest that sales-focused roles can hold outsized influence in B2B settings. This aligns with the longitudinal study by La Rocca et al. (2016), conducted in a robotics B2B company, which highlights Sales’ capacity to shape solutions through connective, cross-organizational work even without formal hierarchical authority: “Sales exercise influence without the tools of hierarchy (…) Sales engage in multiple interactions and orchestrate the pattern of interactions across organizations by connecting and motivating others and mediating when needed. The role of sales in the early stages of new solutions appears to require a particular set of skills and capabilities different from what is usually associated with the role of sales in other contexts.” (La Rocca et al., 2016, p. 55) In practice, especially where no formal UX function exists or is newly established, Sales’ long-standing customer relationships and stakeholder access may enable them to gather and channel product-shaping insights, which can persist culturally even as UX capabilities mature.

4.2.6 Senior Management, Vice Presidents, and C-level members

For all respondents, these actors were placed in the outermost circle of the ego-centric maps. They remained stakeholders who matter for overall success, but were described as difficult to reach and influence directly. P2 captures this dynamic when reflecting on an exploratory UX approach:

“I think the further you go out, the more difficult it becomes because you sometimes have to convince the people on the way to the furthest person. So I would say like the

VP of Video is hard to influence, but not because he doesn't believe in what we do, right. So this person is very important to have on my side, otherwise the project does not really pass. If you can imagine that I start from a vague idea and at some point down the line, I hope that's my dream to make it happen, that it becomes a realistic product that is on the market, then that is the VP of Video that essentially also should be the sponsor, the stakeholder that says: Yes, let's do it.“

Across cases, senior leaders were seen as broadly supportive of UX in principle, with the extent of support shaped by the organization’s design maturity and by each leader’s perspective. As P4 noted, “I think there has been a lot of work already done to communicate the value of UX.” In P1’s company, the CEO played a particularly positive role: “The CEO has helped us quite a lot because he had the idea that we should actually be customer driven, and he saw the value of it. (...) He’s saying that it's the thing that will make us different in the market.”

At the same time, participants emphasized a gap between top-level enthusiasm and an understanding of downstream user impact, especially in Enterprise contexts where “customer-driven” and “user-driven” are not synonymous. P3 put it this way: “I see the C-Suite as people who are, you know, they want to say ‘Let's do it, let‘s go all in’. Yeah, we'll do that but I don't think that they will necessarily understand exactly how it's going to influence the end user. They are in different sphere, different zone and that also makes them difficult to approach,” and added, “UX is done when it's done. But from a C-suite perspective, it's done because it's Tuesday.”

When communicating with senior management, participants described favouring concise, decision-oriented formats. P1 shared: “They tend to like most to have numbers or to have like a Power BI dashboard or something like that that we present to them and then discuss from there. (...) For the Senior Management and for the CFO, it's numbers and it's results that we need to present.” P3 echoed the emphasis on brevity and synthesis: “Upper Management people want the top findings. Maybe a data visualizations with a few quotes, like six slides, something like that. But for these really in depth, especially like of course the UX, for this we talk about four.

4.2.7 Finding the Bridge Breakers and Bridge Builders

Contrary to my initial assumption, there does not appear to be a single problematic role, such as engineers, that consistently blocks UX research from pushing insights forward. This suggests the difficulty is not rooted in specific people or positions, nor simply in divergent mindsets, but likely lies elsewhere in the system.

As the ego-centric maps indicated, the most consequential stakeholders for this project—the ones where communication is most necessary—are the “bridge builders” (Hamedani et al., 2023) who typically sit in the second or third ring. These people are close enough to be essential to influence, yet far enough from day-to-day design work to hold different priorities and to be harder to reach. In the first ring, participants most often placed other UXers and designers, followed by more technical collaborators such as developers and engineers, and then product management. Except for engineers in one case, these groups were generally described as easier to influence. They are directly involved in making the product, and interviewees characterised them as wanting the whole story and the underlying data, which aligns with how designers naturally communicate. There is also substantial prior work on easing friction between designers and engineers that can be drawn upon in these situations.

The picture changes in the second and third rings. Here, the roles included Marketing, Sales or Account Managers, and layers of management. According to participants, these stakeholders tend to prefer quantitative evidence, which can clash with the qualitative centre of gravity in UX practice. Yet, particularly in Sales, these actors are verbally adept and highly influential over outcomes, a dynamic also supported by La Rocca et al. (2016).

4.3 If the stakeholders are not the problem, where else may it be?

Large organisations are complex, and the relationships within them are even more so. The mapping results may reflect Denmark’s relatively flat work hierarchy, as suggested by Hofstede’s low power-distance score of 18 (Country Comparison Tool, n.d.), or they may be specific to this particular group of designers. If, in the view of these

professionals, no single role or department is directly blocking impact, the question becomes: where and when does perceived importance dissipate?

The literature points to several systemic factors, including the company's overall design maturity (Pernice et al., 2024; Vetrov, 2013), communication that misses stakeholder needs or preferences (Gorichanaz, 2025; Coutts et al., 2018; Lachner et al., 2016), and development processes that are not set up with design in mind (Kashfi et al., 2016). Against that backdrop, the issues identified by interviewees are as follows.

4.3.1 Changes of Strategy

Organizations are dynamic social systems in which personnel, structures, and priorities continually shift. As roles and reporting lines change, the relative position and perceived value of UX also change. In many firms, UX is framed as a preventive capability rather than a core driver of product direction: its contribution becomes most visible when it mitigates risk, surfaces latent user needs, or restores coherence after issues emerge. Commercial activity is often prioritized as the immediate engine of growth, while long-term investments in usability and product quality are treated as discretionary. This logic echoes the common product-strategy shorthand that "painkillers" are easier to justify than "vitamins," privileging reactive fixes over proactive UX investment.

Reorganizations make this pattern especially salient because activities perceived as nonessential are the first to be reduced. As P1 observed: "We lost a lot of a lot of influence in the reorganizations because things needs to be faster and be less pricey. And of course, when you need to do research, it takes time and it also has a price, and some of that has been cut out." P5 reinforced the cyclical nature of deprioritizing research in downturns: "It's probably something that comes back every time there's a recession, you know, like it feels like it's the work that can wait."

At the same time, strategic influence can accumulate gradually as colleagues observe the concrete outcomes of UX work and informally advocate for it. This diffusion often depends on patient coalition-building and the emergence of "bridge builders" who

translate UX value across functions (Hamedani et al., 2023). As P1 reflected: “When you want to work as a strategic UX designer, you have to have patience. So that's one of the things that I have learned the hard way and I, especially, have long talks with our CEO. When I started here he said: ‘You need to be patient’ because I was trying to do everything at once and he was like ‘No, it's not possible. It's going to take you 10 years, please, have that patience.’ And then it's like, OK, I will try to be patient to make it work. And it is like that.”

Frequent restructurings can both hinder and enable this process. They introduce instability and competing agendas, but they also create openings for UX-sympathetic leaders to move into roles with broader remit. P2 described this mixed reality: “We have had restructures in the RD department. We have had restructures where I was moved outside my team, right. Me and my team were moved outside the R&D department, then into the Product Management or the Enterprise that‘s we call it, and we have had changes of CEOs. We have had changes of people moving from one role to another role, we have had people resign, we have people laid off, we have people hired. I think it's a mixture of so many things with new ideas, fresh ideas, trying things out, not working out, promises being made, but not being held. And I think it (the company) has naturally matured because there have been people who have been pushing. I know at least my manager, and not today's manager only, but also previous managers, and then their managers have been pushing like the whole idea of what UX has as of what it can offer to the company, and what design in general also can offer to the company.” P5 highlighted the dependence of UX on stable, aligned sponsorship: “I've been at a place where I was supported by the boss, it was just that the boss changed direction every two weeks. Which is very bad for UX work, right?”

In sum, company strategy and restructuring are major determinants of Enterprise UX influence. Shifts in priorities can slow long-term efforts to raise design maturity, yet they can also elevate allies who later champion UX from senior positions. Durable influence appears to come from near-field advocacy — convincing stakeholders in adjacent circles — and from those allies carrying UX knowledge upward over time.

4.3.2 The Difference between Customer and User

“I’m going to be introduced to a new colleague that’s going to be in charge of our participants’ setup where we have hired so far sixty just as consultants to actually give us the continuous feedback on all of our products. Before, sales owned everything because they were the only one who in touch with customers. But of course they see it’s not the same as making the product better for the end user,” explained P3, supporting the previously introduced idea of sales acting as de facto UX in smaller companies (La Rocca et al., 2016). That sales-derived insight is not the same as UX—and that customer may not be the same as user—is often forgotten or used interchangeably, as noted earlier by P1. Blurring this distinction can be harmful to usability.

For UX to operate effectively and set a viable strategy, stakeholders must cooperate (Levy, 2015). Yet the organization’s dominant view of who the “customer” is can also set company strategy. If that strategy is weak, unclear, or guided primarily by short-term revenue interests, the result can be highly unpleasant for UX designers: “This company has a super concrete vision. And that would mean if anyone came to us and said: ‘We want to be able to do X, and we will pay you for this if you do it.’ We will say no, that’s not our vision, sorry, go to someone else. And that is the courage a company needs in order to do great UX because if you don’t do that, it will always be just having two different mindsets in the same software. That makes it impossible to make great UX. (...) If the vision is not clear, then it’s easy for the customers to take control of the company,” shared P3. This adds another layer to UX strategy: even a well-reasoned approach struggles if the broader business is not financially stable or aligned.

If Sales say “our customers need this,” they usually mean the budget-holding managers. Application Engineers, by contrast, may know the product so well that they overlook basic issues faced by everyday users. Without a clear internal champion for the user and a shared distinction between user and customer, products risk being shaped by buyers’ opinions rather than by actual usage. Marketing-wise, having someone with a UX title may be enough to label a product “user-friendly,” but the real issue is communication and shared understanding of for whom the product is being

created — and UX is the function best placed to align that. Misalignment creates unmet expectations for Enterprise UX, especially when the organizational direction effectively targets someone other than the end user.

Customer capture happens easily in B2B contexts. “It’s a matter of really trying to find that balance and having a good dialogue with your customer there. And it can easily become that way that the customer controls your product development because they are the ones saying: ‘we only need this’,” shared P1. “But you always have to be in dialogue with the customer and then say: ‘OK, but if you cut out that I have round corners or you cut out that I take time to work with the colours or something like that, then you also cut out some of the value. Are you ready to do that or is it the reason why you thought of buying our product in the 1st place, actually? That we had some of those cool features?’ And then that’s the discussion that you need to have with the customer.” This suggests that even if buyers are not the end users, visual and experiential quality can still signal trustworthiness and value (Pallavi et al., 2023). P3, however, warns about over-fitting to a single buyer: “If we follow this single customer that we don’t even know if we’re going to get the money from, we’re going to build something that no other customer can use. Then they (internal stakeholders) will ask: ‘How certain are you that no other customer wants to use this?’ (...) So yeah, that’s where things go wrong. But because I also have this experience as being an entrepreneur I’m also to blame. I have also followed the money and didn’t care about anything else. I know exactly how it is.”

For customers to appreciate the downstream impact of design changes—on other customers, on maintainability, and on the cost of one-off features—someone must frame and communicate those trade-offs convincingly inside the company. In practice, this means UXers must connect the value of design to each stakeholder’s goals and equip allies in Sales and Product with arguments they can carry forward.

4.3.3 Data Gathering and Time

A recurring challenge, especially for P4, was access to data: “The thing is with tracking for us, it’s a blocker that we rely on the software developers. So it’s not just something that you can just click around and say like, ‘OK, I’m gonna track this funnel.’

I can't make the decision because we don't track it but we can't track it because— you know, and then it goes. (...) So then then I have to really advocate for the value of things." As an internal Enterprise UXer, P4 can still gather some data. In external Enterprise UX, however, data access is often severely restricted due to confidentiality concerns, making standard consumer-grade analytics tools inappropriate.

Insufficient data was also P5's biggest blocker: "I think mostly I've met failure when I've tried to tone it down. So when I've tried to do less, maybe test pilot been like: 'No, no, it's OK. I can just talk to two people or It's fine, I can just do this.' That's when I meet failure. Because then, of course, the product will not be as good." P4 echoed the time pressure: "So there is not always the luxury of doing the proper discovery research because I'm doing both research and design. So sometimes when there are, you know, MVPs, there are tight deadlines, then then it can be very solution-driven." This reflects today's fast-paced product environments, where scope and timing often shift.

Long timelines can also backfire: "Imagine you work on something for a year and in between, towards the end, management changes. Their minds are different. They have different opinions. Your ideas? 'Cool, but we will move on to something else'," shared P2. P3 adopts a more iterative stance: "I don't think that I ever felt that my designs were lost. They just changed directions. I guess that's also because I've never seen UX as a final thing. It is meant to be iterative." For P4, being a "one-woman show" means she can often return to paused work when priorities settle.

Overall, unpredictability plus pressure for rapid, "valuable" results without adequate data creates a difficult cycle. Cutting research too far can yield weak evidence, which undermines credibility and resources the next time. Where possible, negotiating conditions up front, selecting high-impact pilots, and sequencing work to produce early, decision-ready insights may help rebuild trust in Enterprise settings.

4.3.4 Respect, Career, and a Seat at the C-Table

The question of UX's importance resonates strongly in the current market. As a visible organizer in the local UX community, P5 noted: "With the with the community, what I've learned is you need to be able to juggle. (...) I do a this and that because we do need

to be able to make our ideas come to life within a company, and that could require more skills." Acceptance often follows demonstrated value: "Our work has been accepted, you could say, more because we have had opportunities to prove to certain level of managements that the work that we do is insightful and it can help us make decisions," shared P2.

Even so, UX rarely reaches executive roles, which can push some to leave. P1 recounted: "So I was together with a lot of people last autumn at training session in Austria (...) and there were especially two German UX leads (...) and they both had this issue that they could not make it to the next level and designers are not thought in on C-levels. So there is still like a lot of room for having designers on C- level, because you can say: 'Why is it that we excluded on C level?' Because the Sales and UX is the ones talking to the customers and trying to get the customer perspective in but that value. (....) People came up with all of those ideas about how they should do it and so on. And they were like: 'No, no, no. I'm going to quit my job because they cannot see the value,' and so on." She also reflected on her own trajectory: "So I can tell you totally honestly that I've had the same title since I joined the company five years ago. Would I have expected that if I was an engineer? I would expect to have a career road in front of me, where the company would have offered me at least to change my title once or twice over five years. I would not have expected just to stay at the same level. But when there is no designers in the organization and there is no one to pave the way, then you only have yourself."

This highlights how, beyond mastering tools or collecting technical skills, many UXers struggle to prove their contribution and feel their work is scrutinized more than others'. P1 describes compensating by proactively reporting to leadership: "So I normally do every half year a report that I share to to senior management team and to the CFO saying: 'OK, what is it that UX and product design has provided within the last half year' (...) in order to make sure that we are still prioritized. And that's so stupid because it's not something that is needed normally, right? Because you will never ask a product manager to do that, but on the other hand, it's my safety in also showing: 'OK, this is

what my group of people have worked with and have done.' Because it's so easy when there's a crisis like there is right now, it's always the creative people that you cut out." P3, laid off during a crisis, later moved into a Product Owner role: "It's just the name of my job, that's the only thing that changed. It's kind of the same company, same problem, same issues, same types of people. I'm the same person, I'm saying the same things, but suddenly it just works. It's really weird."

The title "designer" still carries a stereotype of "making things pretty," despite public efforts to challenge that view (Norman, 2016). Combined with development approaches that historically under-integrate design roles (Kashfi et al., 2016), this can make UX appear as a drag on speed. Yet the accounts here suggest the barrier is as much about perception and communication as about process: when colleagues give UX space to demonstrate value—or when the same person holds a less "design-coded" title—their influence can increase markedly.

4.4 Their Current Ways of Influencing Stakeholders

If the barrier lies in how work is communicated or understood, then it becomes essential to examine what Enterprise UXers actually do today: how they present outcomes, what counts as a success, and which direct and indirect tactics they rely on. Many of the practices below were framed by the interviewees as advice to peers, grounded in what has worked for them in Enterprise contexts.

4.4.1 Gathering Strategic Data on Top

"We're in the process lately to to get more into quantitative, which is a journey (...) So to also have the have numbers as part of the story because that can be sometimes a blocker of like: 'Yes, of course, you talk to five users. (...) But how many of our users actually do that? Is it just because they are the experts?' So to bring those systems in as well," shared P4. All interviewees reported using at least some form of quantitative data collection alongside qualitative work. Common examples included surveys and standardized scores such as NPS (net promoter score), CSAT (customer satisfaction),

QXscore, and SUS (System Usability Scale), as well as selectively reusing relevant studies produced elsewhere in the organization.

Even when the primary interest of UX is qualitative depth, numbers can help establish a baseline for strategy discussions and create traction with stakeholders who expect metrics. As P3 explained: “But this survey is for a layer in the company that is more concerned about like strategic positioning. They don't know the products well enough to be, from UX perspective, interesting.” And as P4 noted: “The System Usability Scale (...) It‘s just another number to track. Again, is it perfect? I don't know what is perfect but at least it gives us another number of like: ‘OK is the experience good enough?’, and that is also a goal that we can strive towards to improve that experience.” In practice, interviewees described balancing quant and qual, using metrics to open doors and qualitative evidence to explain why the numbers look the way they do.

4.4.2 Writing Reports and Documenting

In organizations of this size, knowledge evaporates quickly unless it is captured. Documentation serves two purposes: it preserves hard-won insights when people move on, and it keeps UX visible to the rest of the business. P2 emphasized richer formats: “Two methods that are more demanding, but they're definitely also quite powerful is the video. One, you can reuse it whenever, right. And it’s not dependent on whether you are there anymore or not, so that's also something the company appreciates in terms of documentation.”

P1 highlighted how infrastructure helps stakeholders help themselves: “We have a research database which has thirty thousand insights inside it. (...) That’s also a huge advantage for us. So, when talking to stakeholders, that's some of the things that I try to outline a lot and say: ‘OK, this is where you can get the help, and this is how to use this and here's who to contact if you need help there’ and so on. So that they get to see the value as soon as possible in that, I think that helps.” Clear, findable records reduce duplication, accelerate decision-making, and make the contribution of UX concrete.

4.4.3 Keeping Their Stakeholders Involved

Several participants stressed ongoing involvement rather than episodic “handoffs.” As P2 put it: “Something we designers do best — involve people. (...) Engaging people into the work that you do more gives you more back. (...) Show them what you can do. Show them your value, so to say. So they get familiar with it, so they can see out how we work. And the same goes the other way around, right? Let's say account managers, what value do they bring to you?”

P4 linked involvement to everyday proximity: “I think definitely involving them and having the interaction because, also compared to previous companies, here I have almost daily contact with at least some of the engineers,” which reflects the advantages of working on internal tools. Workshops were another shared tactic. P2 described co-sensemaking to build ownership: “If they are invited to a workshop that is about making a conclusion or synthetising the data in a way with you, so you make them come up with a conclusion. You make them see that this is what the results are, right? And if you do that, that can also be powerful in terms of them remembering and saying: ‘Now I own this conclusion. I was part of making that conclusion,’ and that's also super powerful.”

Conversely, a lack of contact can signal risk. P3 observed: “If they have been in the company for some time and I haven't talked to them... You know, even if there were five hundred people, I talk to basically everyone, it’s just part of the job. You need to understand everyone. But if there's someone with who, for many reasons, you haven't got to talk to, you need to first start out by understanding why haven't you talked to them. You know, what's wrong — because something will be wrong.”

4.4.4 Translating to People of Different Backgrounds

Interviewees adapted their communication to the audience and context. The need for tailoring varied with role and exposure. While P4 presents to many of the same colleagues regularly, she still calibrates tone and framing: “And of course, if you are negotiating with product, I don't argue with them. So if we want to convince them, then

the more business language you use, the better.” P5 described preparing differently for senior stakeholders versus peers: “Learn when are you communicating to the higher-ups and when are you communicating to your peers. (...) They don't want all the text and they don't want all the things. So sometimes I have to make a brief and be like, OK, this brief I'm making is probably gonna be seen by five people, and if I'm lucky they all read it. So, it's been like figuring out the balance of where we need to go with things.”

Taken together, these accounts align with the broader pattern from the stakeholder maps: closest collaborators often want deeper narratives and method details, whereas roles further out prefer succinct takeaways, evidence at a glance, and clear implications for roadmaps and revenue. Translating accordingly helps insights travel, be accepted, and ultimately be implemented.

4.4.5 Making Their Work Visible, Literally

Having visited three interviewees’ workplaces and seen parts of others’ offices online, it was clear that UXers often make their work—intentionally or not—physically visible. Characteristic post its in P5 and P2’s office backgrounds that map progress or ideas, P3’s large printed backlog for crossing off tasks behind him, and P1’s prominent sign in the old office reading “You are not the user” — all of these are tangible cues that make the work visible, invite curiosity, and spark informal conversations. Such interactions can be helpful when times get tough and impact is judged by who appears productive or whose job title sounds more “valuable” than what has actually been delivered. To gain credibility, relationships matter; and to build a network of relationships, one’s work and knowledge must be interesting or useful to others (Mosleh & Larsen, 2020). UX work can also be made visible in more creative ways. P1 described one project: „For instance, we have created 5 different archetypes, so they're not like personas, but their behavioural archetype based on their behaviour. And when we were in our old building, we had like meeting rooms decorated for each archetype, meaning that we got the engineers used to talking about it: ‚OK, I'll go to the Scrabby Hacker. I'll go to the Reliant Rookie.‘ And in the meeting rooms we had then put artifacts in that showed the

different behavioural archetype were and how they would react in certain situations and so on. So we tried to create a language that they could also understand.“

4.4.6 Making Themselves Noticeable to Stakeholders

A distinctive tactic in Enterprise UX is to be slightly disruptive in how one shows up as a person. Because stakeholder attention, trust, and access to internal users are essential for testing and meaningful outcomes, some participants consciously built a recognisable “brand” inside the company. P3 shared his approach: „The small talk is just so important, saying ‚hi‘ when you when you meet them, cracking a joke. I wear funny T-shirts. I also think that it‘s fun, but the main purpose is really for it to be an icebreaker for my job. And then when you start talking, everything else just becomes so much easier because otherwise some people will only tell you what they think you want to hear.“

Designers also use small, intentional behaviours to stimulate new perspectives, unlock creativity, or ensure they are noticed in meetings. P2 explained: „My way would be then to ask questions to highlight myself or to ask something that is relevant to let's say my role or to my tasks or to the process that influences my tasks, if that's what the meeting is about.“ P5 described a simple nudge: „I‘ll usually take a new spot in the meeting room every time we have a meeting because it will make people notice you. This is just basic nudging, right? You're making everybody else take a stance on where do they need to sit? Because you're sitting in a new spot.“

Overall, seizing opportunities to make themselves and their work visible appears to strengthen internal relationships and foster more candid stakeholder interactions, which ultimately improves the quality and honesty of testing outcomes.

4.5 The Identified Issue within the Wicked Problem

Contrary to my initial assumptions, there does not appear to be a single “problematic” stakeholder group consistently blocking UX work. Engineers and developers were often collaborative when involved early, and product managers tended to be close allies. The friction shows up mainly outside the immediate product circle, where UX must

repeatedly justify its usefulness to roles that are farther from users and closer to revenue or reputation. In those second- and third-ring relationships, stakeholders prefer succinct, quantitative signals (e.g., NPS, SUS, dashboards) over qualitative depth, which aligns with prior observations about the need to “speak numbers” in some settings (Lachner et al., 2016; Moran, 2024). At the same time, influence often hinges on informal “bridge builders” rather than formal structure (Hamedani et al., 2023). Sales and account roles, in particular, emerged as powerful shapers of direction in B2B contexts, since they broker access and can align or derail priorities depending on how value is framed (La Rocca et al., 2016).

The challenge, then, is not one of confronting outright opponents but of navigating a system where priorities are unevenly distributed. UX is welcomed when it clearly supports delivery or risk reduction, yet questioned when it seems to slow decisions or introduce complexity. Many stakeholders outside the core product group see UX as “nice to have” unless it is tied directly to customer contracts, revenue protection, or public reputation. As a result, designers often need to translate insights into formats that match what others already trust—numbers, benchmarks, rankings—rather than rely only on stories or empathy-building exercises. Timing also plays a role: when UX evidence arrives after key choices have been locked in, it has little chance to shape the outcome, no matter how strong the findings.

What makes this dynamic more complex is the split between “customer” and “user.” In enterprise settings, the person buying the product is rarely the same as the one using it day-to-day. Sales and account managers operate in the customer space, while UX tends to sit with the user. Without deliberate efforts to bridge those perspectives, misalignment can grow: a product may technically satisfy the contract but frustrate its actual users. This is where informal relationships matter. A supportive sales contact, a curious engineer, or a product manager willing to share airtime can make the difference between UX being sidelined or included at the right moment. In practice, then, the real obstacle is less about hostile individuals and more about translation,

timing, and access in an environment where UX's link to profitability is indirect and often invisible.

5 Challenging the UX Influence Through Design

The ego-centric maps I designed were useful as a first step for helping UXers name the people they work with and visualize proximity and influence. However, they did not directly suggest what to do next. Before arriving at the mapping approach, I explored several concept directions as the project kept shifting in response to "stumbled-upon" data (Brinkmann, 2014).

At the outset, I considered outlining a profile of a *UX Designer 5.0* and the skills such a practitioner might need. The farther I progressed, however, the more pressing the question became whether "UX designers" will even exist as a distinct category in Industry 5.0 or Society 5.0. That question pushed me toward clarifying how *user*, *customer*, and *human* are not interchangeable in B2B contexts, and why they should be recognized and treated differently in practice. This chapter goes into depth of the Phase 5 of the process (see **Figure 14**).

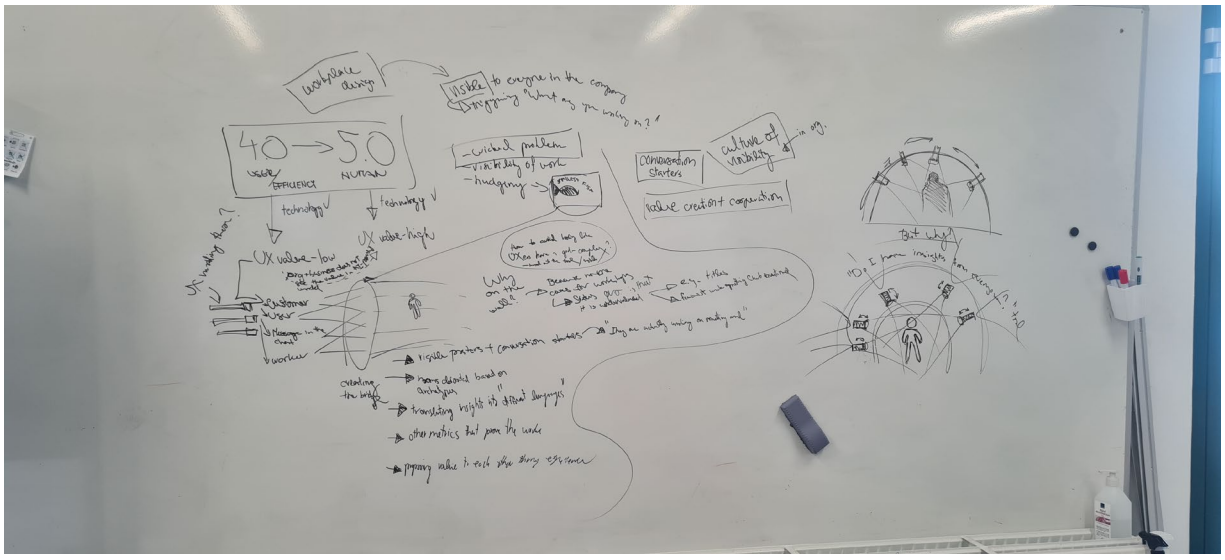


Figure 14. *Initial thoughts and preparation. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

This led to early exploratory mock-ups aimed at communicating those differing points of view inside organizations. I imagined interactive forms that could make the distinction tangible and persuasive. On re-reading the interviews, though, I realized that trying to shift the wider organization through artifacts alone — especially among people who do not yet see design as central — was unlikely to land as intended. Such

pieces risked becoming yet another poster or sign (like “You are not the user”) that designers already produce and that colleagues may glance at and ignore (**see Figure 15**).



Figure 15. *Designing to challenge the enterprises’ perception on UX. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

I therefore refocused the design effort on the designer rather than the organization. It is usually easier to change one’s own preparation, framing, and tactics than to change an entire company. The goal became to help UXers understand their influence pathways and prepare for pivotal moments of persuasion. That turn produced several tool sketches, later consolidated into the mapping concept used in interviews.

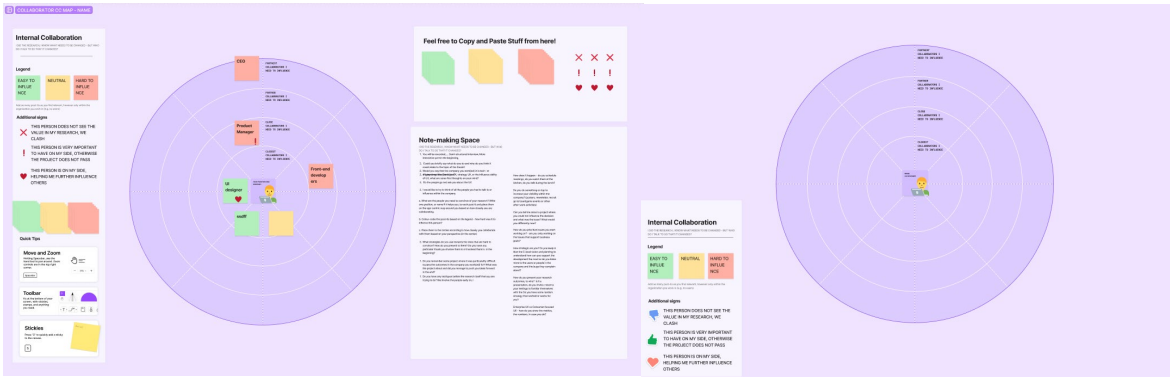


Figure 16*. Initial prototypes of the ego-centric maps. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

The maps (**Figure 16**) worked as a shared reference point, but they did not confirm my initial hypothesis that one role group (for example, engineers) is “the” barrier. Instead, the analysis pointed toward structure, timing, and power dynamics —

especially the outsized influence of stakeholders who typically sit in the second or third ring of the UXer's network. Those roles are close enough to matter yet far enough from day-to-day product work to prioritize different evidence and incentives. Among them, Sales emerged as particularly consequential.

La Rocca et al. (2016) show how Sales can accumulate informal power by brokering relationships, orchestrating interactions, and mediating across boundaries. In several ways, UX occupies a similar boundary-spanning position, but often without a direct connection to revenue, which weakens its bargaining power. A plausible minimum intervention, then, is to help designers "sell" their work more effectively — by planning negotiations, framing value in audience-appropriate terms, and connecting UX outcomes to what specific stakeholders need to win (**Figure 17**).

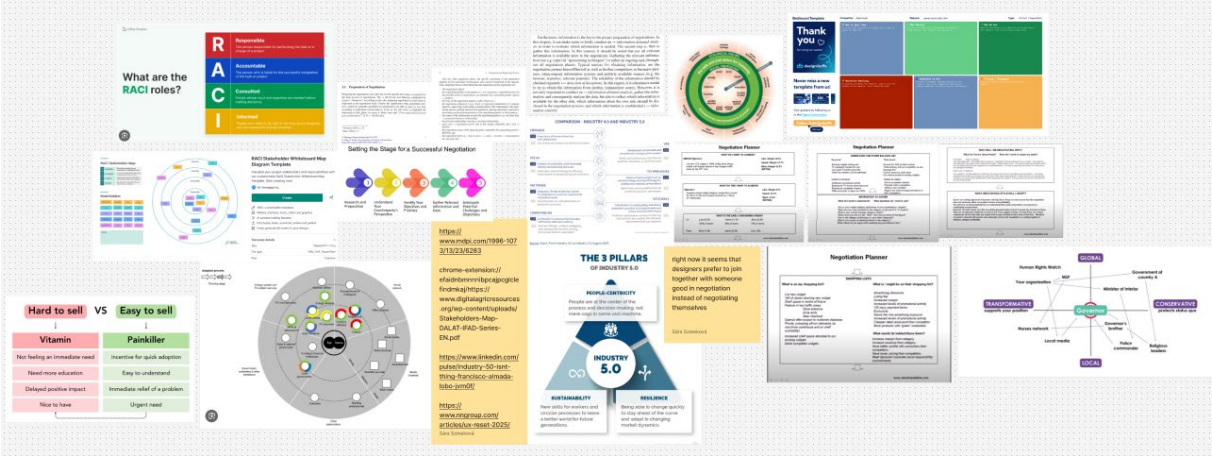


Figure 17. *Gathering inspiration for the designs. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

Here my prior experience in Marketing, and close collaboration with Sales and Account Managers, was useful. Sales teams routinely prepare with negotiation frameworks and tactical aids. One common artifact is the "battle card": a concise, structured summary of the competitive landscape, key strengths and weaknesses, likely objections, and recommended counters (e.g., McPheat, 2023). Card-based tools also have a long lineage in design, where they help summarize complex information, prompt discussion, and guide process steps in a compact, portable format (Roy & Warren, 2019).

Therefore I attempted to createone pack as well (**Figure 18**). In B2B settings, Sales cycles are long and multi-threaded, which forces disciplined preparation. That discipline has a clear parallel in Enterprise UX, where influencing the second and third rings requires forethought, messaging choices, and timely follow-ups rather than ad-hoc persuasion.



Figure 18*. Initial first sketch of the negotiation cards. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

I also drew on negotiation checklists and tactic sheets (e.g., Hazeldine, 2014; **Figure 19**). Many of those frameworks emphasize listening over talking, building on what the other party values, and co-creating solutions — habits that align naturally with UX practice. Several interviewees already highlighted listening as a strength (see P2), which suggested that a lightweight scaffold could help UXers channel that strength into sharper, more repeatable influence.

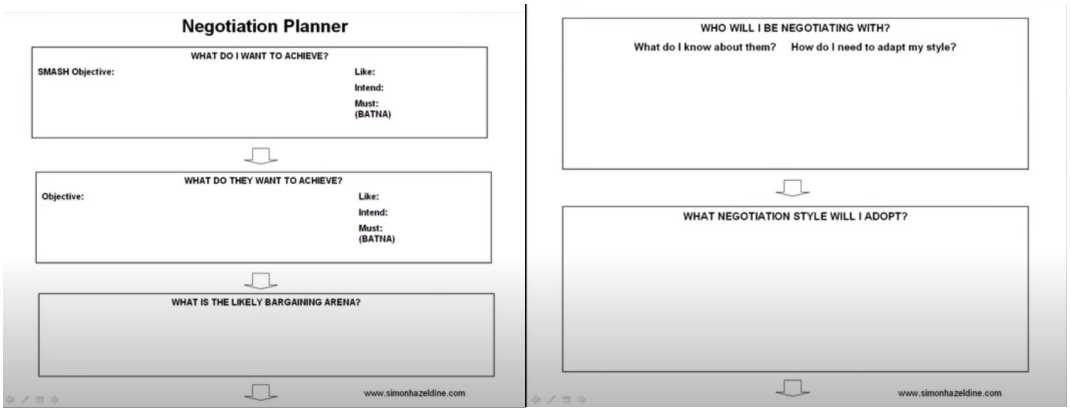


Figure 19. *Inspiration from negotiation planners. Hazeldine, 2014. Source: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dXKZGikCcEY*

A cautionary thread from the interviews also shaped the concept. In P1's story, two experienced German UX leads were close to giving up. Their situation suggested a risk of learned helplessness after repeated failures to effect change. That reinforced my aim to create something that feels actionable and confidence-building — a tool that helps designers prepare, enter conversations with clearer intent, and notice small wins.

Several practical constraints guided the design brief: (1) reduce paper use and fit with online collaboration norms; (2) avoid creating the impression that UX is "collecting intelligence" on colleagues; (3) provide a single place to capture stakeholder knowledge and align the team's influence strategy; and (4) make the content easy to update as people move roles or priorities change.

Although this thesis is not product-focused, the core takeaway is that preparing for internal negotiation in Enterprise settings is a design problem in its own right. Each stakeholder expects different kinds of evidence and framing. Being ready—having the arguments, likely objections, counters, and follow-ups laid out — can help UXers operate more confidently in the second and third rings of their networks. In practice, that means writing things down, visualizing the plan, rehearsing stakeholder-specific narratives, and building the muscle of translating UX value to others' goals. It may also

mean learning directly from Sales about the negotiation approaches that already work inside the company.

In that spirit, I treated the prototype as both a research archetype and a means of inquiry (Wensveen & Matthews, 2014): a tangible form of my understanding that participants could challenge for usefulness, blind spots, and tone. The objective was not to finalize a "solution," but to create an empowering scaffold that helps UXers open doors to conversations they have struggled to enter. The slide-deck implementation presented here (See *Attachments*) is one possible form; the underlying knowledge could evolve into other formats as teams adapt it to their contexts.

5.1 The Proposed prototype

Synthesising the different strands of data, I developed a prototype intended not as a finished solution but as a stimulus for critique and co-creation by UX professionals. This move is consistent with an abductive stance that privileges *showing to learn* over early closure (Brinkmann, 2014) and with pre-design/generative practices that use provisional artefacts to surface tacit knowledge and future possibilities (Sanders & Stappers, 2014). I re-engaged two earlier participants (P1 and P4) to interrogate the concept. Each of them separately on an online video call in English, taking around thirty minutes.

The artefact is a slide-based **Enterprise UX Negotiation Cards** built in Figma, selected for its ubiquity in design teams and ease of internal team-only access. It extends the ego-centric mapping activity (**Figure 20**) as the opening step and then introduces editable, interview-derived stakeholder personas (see *Attachments*). These archetypes are deliberately minimal, based on the research in Chapter 4, so they can be adapted to different organisational contexts. A final slide aggregates the study's cross-cutting insights into a compact guide on "what additional evidence to gather, and for whom," enabling teams to plan their evidence mix before key interactions. To support systematic preparation, I incorporated prompts from negotiation planning (Hazeldine,

2014), including counterpart goals, likely objections, potential concessions, and provisional walk-away lines.



Figure 20. *The scheme of the proposed prototype. Szmeková, 2025. Source: Author*

Note: First, the stakeholders are determined by the UXer (1), then each slide with individual negotation information is filled in (2), and the last overall negotiation strategy for the project (3).

5.1.1 Reactions from the Designers

T Separating the online ideation sessions yielded complementary perspectives. P4 emphasised onboarding and team alignment value in large organisations, while noting that in her current setting—a small, stable internal group—continuous use would be limited. She suggested alternative embodiments: “Teams like mine, which is in big corporations, you will find then you are all supporting different people. Maybe this could be a team exercise as well, how to increase the influence of UX or how to have this ROI discussions with your stakeholders.” She also noted it could function as physical cards, a workshop pack, or a lightweight framework.

P1 focused on effort, reuse, and simulation. She cautioned against heavy documentation overhead and proposed leveraging generalisable patterns and role-play with simple agents: “It's a lot of work to get it written down. (…) But then what you could do is that you could actually use the AI agents, create an AI agent for each of them and put that on top so that you say, OK, now I have an agent who is actually an executive or now I have an agent who is actually from sales.” In response, I kept the personas concise and editable and experimented with a personalised ChatGPT setup that replies in line with the study’s findings. Although created, this was not formally tested. However, it appears promising as a low-risk environment for rehearsing difficult conversations.

Overall, the feedback supports the prototype's role as a pragmatic thinking device: it externalises stakeholder assumptions, scaffolds negotiation preparation, and creates a shared reference for how UX evidence is assembled and communicated inside Enterprise contexts.

6 Discussion

Returning to the framing in Sections 1.1 and 2, AI has intensified substitution pressure on visible UX activities such as quick wireframes, multiple UI variants, or early layout explorations. These are the parts of the discipline that are easiest to automate because they produce tangible outputs that can be generated from prompts or templates. My data, however, show that in Enterprise environments influence rarely depends on artifacts alone. Instead, it is built around the slower, less visible work of translation, negotiation, and orchestrating relationships with stakeholders who sit just beyond the immediate product circle. This resonates strongly with the direction of Industry 5.0, which calls for human-centric collaboration across functions. Organizational value is not created when UX simply produces polished screens; it emerges when UX connects evidence to decisions, enabling alignment between technical feasibility, business priorities, and user needs. The findings therefore suggest that designable supports should focus on negotiation, stakeholder alignment, and organizational learning — areas where AI may accelerate certain tasks but cannot replace the situated human judgment involved in navigating organizational politics and relationships.

6.1 Stakeholder landscape and influence points (RQ1)

The interviews suggest a more nuanced stakeholder picture than my initial assumptions. Day-to-day collaboration was strongest in the first ring of the ego-centric maps: product managers, engineers, developers, and fellow designers. With these roles, participants described steady access, shared artifacts, and a willingness to engage when evidence and rationale were visible. Engineers, often thought of as skeptical, did not appear as a uniform source of resistance. Tension, when it did arise, was less about rejection of user evidence and more about structural differences: many engineers versus few designers, inherited technical debt that constrained options, or different definitions of what counted as “done.” When involved early and shown transparent

methods, engineers and developers were generally supportive and sometimes became strong advocates for user-centered perspectives.

The more consequential friction and leverage points, however, appeared one orbit further out. These “near-adjacent” actors are still linked to product outcomes but are not present in the daily stand-ups or design reviews. In my sample, sales, account management, and marketing carried particular weight. In other firms, the equivalent roles might sit in operations, finance, compliance, support, or analytics. The common denominator is that they share accountability for business success but lack direct, regular contact with end users. Because of this distance, they value concise, outcome-oriented evidence rather than detailed process explanations. When UX engaged them deliberately, they often became powerful allies and bridge builders, helping translate insights into commercially relevant terms. When neglected, however, they became bottlenecks, slowing or derailing initiatives by framing UX as peripheral.

Sales is especially strategic in B2B contexts. Beyond controlling access to customer accounts, sales teams frame value in ways that spread across the organization. Their narratives can amplify user-centered findings if they are aligned, or undermine them if customer requests are treated as more important than broader usability evidence. This dynamic highlights why mapping stakeholder rings matters. The second and third rings contain the people most worth winning over, because their advocacy can carry UX priorities into rooms where designers are not present. In short, support clustered with close collaborators who saw user risks directly, while persistent setbacks clustered with influential roles slightly further away, where the language of value differed from the language of research.

6.2 Coping strategies and obstacles in the current environment (RQ2)

Participants described an environment shaped by post-pandemic pressures: layoffs, reorganizations, tighter budgets, and rising expectations that automation and AI will take over repetitive work. Within this context, four recurring obstacles limited the movement of research into decisions and implementation:

1. **Evidence access and timing.** In Internal Enterprise contexts, UX often depends on engineering to enable tracking and telemetry. In External Enterprise contexts, strict confidentiality rules limit the availability of analytics. Under deadline pressure, discovery is compressed, leaving thinner evidence bases that later weaken credibility.
2. **Strategic churn.** Frequent reorganizations, leadership turnover, or shifting product mandates mean priorities are reset. Work that is not tied to current strategy, or that relies on a single champion, becomes vulnerable to being abandoned.
3. **Customer–user conflation.** In B2B, the buyer is rarely the same as the end user. Sales insights are valuable, but they are not equivalent to user evidence. When this distinction collapses, custom requests or one-off features can outweigh broader usability needs.
4. **Career visibility and role perception.** Designers described limited progression paths and lingering stereotypes of being "the people who make things look nice." Repeated blockages and lack of recognition create emotional strain and can slide toward learned helplessness without visible wins or sponsorship.

To cope, participants used pragmatic and repeatable tactics:

- **Layered evidence.** Combine qualitative insights with lightweight quantitative metrics (e.g., SUS, CSAT, NPS, funnel checks). Numbers act as entry points, not replacements for context.
- **Deliberate documentation.** Short decks, annotated clips, and repositories preserve knowledge across reorganizations and make insights portable. This lowers the cost of re-doing research and ensures continuity.
- **Co-ownership of conclusions.** Facilitate synthesis sessions with non-UX stakeholders so they help generate the takeaways. People are more likely to defend what they had a hand in creating.

- **Audience translation.** Tailor tone and format: detailed rationale for near collaborators, condensed “top findings plus one quote” for senior leaders, business language for product/finance, raw traces for engineers.
- **Everyday visibility work.** Leave artifacts behind, build informal rapport, and show up in cross-team spaces so UX remains visible between big decision points.

Overall, coping meant making the right evidence easy for the right audience at the right moment, while building a network of allies who could carry the story further.

AI shaped these dynamics less by replacing design craft and more by shifting evidence expectations. Leaders increasingly asked for concise numbers, prompting participants to use AI both for acceleration (transcript cleaning, affinity starts, prototype variants) and as a support for lightweight metrics. Yet they also stressed that human judgment remained essential for sampling, ethical reflection, and framing trade-offs — the areas that determine whether research actually influences a decision.

6.3 Practical guidance and designable supports (RQ3)

Participants described an environment shaped by post-pandemic pressures: layoffs, reorganizations, tighter budgets, and rising expectations that automation and AI will take over repetitive work. Within this context, four recurring obstacles limited the movement of research into decisions and implementation:

1. Evidence access and timing. In Internal Enterprise contexts, UX often depends on engineering to enable tracking and telemetry. In External Enterprise contexts, strict confidentiality rules limit the availability of analytics. Under deadline pressure, discovery is compressed, leaving thinner evidence bases that later weaken credibility.
2. Strategic churn. Frequent reorganizations, leadership turnover, or shifting product mandates mean priorities are reset. Work that is not tied to current strategy, or that relies on a single champion, becomes vulnerable to being abandoned.

3. Customer–user conflation. In B2B, the buyer is rarely the same as the end user. Sales insights are valuable, but they are not equivalent to user evidence. When this distinction collapses, custom requests or one-off features can outweigh broader usability needs.
4. Career visibility and role perception. Designers described limited progression paths and lingering stereotypes of being "the people who make things look nice." Repeated blockages and lack of recognition create emotional strain and can slide toward learned helplessness without visible wins or sponsorship.

To cope, participants used pragmatic and repeatable tactics:

- Layered evidence. Combine qualitative insights with lightweight quantitative metrics (e.g., SUS, CSAT, NPS, funnel checks). Numbers act as entry points, not replacements for context.
- Deliberate documentation. Short decks, annotated clips, and repositories preserve knowledge across reorganizations and make insights portable. This lowers the cost of re-doing research and ensures continuity.
- Co-ownership of conclusions. Facilitate synthesis sessions with non-UX stakeholders so they help generate the takeaways. People are more likely to defend what they had a hand in creating.
- Audience translation. Tailor tone and format: detailed rationale for near collaborators, condensed "top findings plus one quote" for senior leaders, business language for product/finance, raw traces for engineers.
- Everyday visibility work. Leave artifacts behind, build informal rapport, and show up in cross-team spaces so UX remains visible between big decision points.

Overall, coping meant making the right evidence easy for the right audience at the right moment, while building a network of allies who could carry the story further.

AI shaped these dynamics less by replacing design craft and more by shifting evidence expectations. Leaders increasingly asked for concise numbers, prompting participants to use AI both for acceleration (transcript cleaning, affinity starts, prototype variants) and as a support for lightweight metrics. Yet they also stressed that human judgment remained essential for sampling, ethical reflection, and framing trade-offs — the areas that determine whether research actually influences a decision.

6.4 Contribution and Limitations

This master's thesis is based on five professionals in total, four of whom held Enterprise-UX roles and therefore completed the ego-centric mapping. The depth-over-breadth choice means that while the material is rich, it may not capture the full diversity of practice; other practitioners may experience different contexts and constraints. Although I intentionally sampled for variation across company size and role seniority, a larger pool within each sub-role could yield a more generalisable picture.

The focus on Enterprise UX also limits transferability. Internal negotiation surely matters to any UXer, yet the stakeholder mix, incentives, and success metrics likely differ for consumer-facing product teams or agency settings. All participants practiced in Denmark, a context known for relatively flat hierarchies; similar findings may not hold in cultures with higher power distance.. In addition, the data are primarily self-reported interview accounts, which introduces subjectivity and potential recall bias. Triangulation from other vantage points—such as interviews with engineering, product, marketing, sales, and executive stakeholders—was outside scope. Finally, the prototype was reviewed with only two participants, and I did not measure downstream behavioural or organisational outcomes.

Despite these limits, the thesis contributes in three ways. First, it makes visible the internal networks around Enterprise UX, showing how influence often hinges on "second- and third-ring" stakeholders who sit near the product team but operate with different incentives and evidence preferences. Second, it surfaces concrete day-to-day

tactics that practitioners already use to maintain traction, from documentation practices to tailored executive briefs. Third, it proposes an actionable, low-friction prototype—the Enterprise UX Negotiation Cards—that teams can adapt quickly within existing toolchains. Together, these contributions offer a pragmatic starting point for strengthening UX influence inside large organisations.

6.5 Conclusion and The Future Outlook

Industry commentary suggests that Enterprise-UX roles may continue to grow in importance (Jakob Nielsen [NNgroup], 2021). Unlike many consumer contexts, Enterprise work rarely revolves around aesthetics alone. Instead, it requires balancing domain-specific complexity, ensuring workflow resilience in high-stakes environments, and demonstrating measurable operational impact. These are areas that current AI-driven layout or copy generators only partially address. While AI can accelerate certain tasks, such as generating interface variants or producing first-pass text, it does not yet resolve questions of compliance, integration with legacy systems, or nuanced trade-offs between efficiency and human factors. If these trends hold, Enterprise UX may prove comparatively future-resilient within the profession's current transition.

At the same time, a parallel risk remains. Stakeholders who still conflate "design" with surface polish may be quick to view AI outputs as cheaper substitutes for UX work. From this perspective, the role of the UX professional could appear diminished, even when the deeper responsibilities of translation, negotiation, and orchestration remain critical. This strengthens the case for UXers to invest not only in their craft skills but also in their ability to negotiate internally, manage stakeholder expectations, and make the less-visible dimensions of their work more legible across the organization. In an environment where budgets are scrutinized and automation is celebrated, demonstrating strategic value becomes a protective measure as well as an opportunity for leadership.

The insights presented here should therefore be read as a starting point for building practical supports that can help sustain influence. The Negotiation Cards concept

represents one such support, and its application could take multiple forms. It could serve as a team exercise for aligning on influence strategies before entering critical conversations; as an onboarding aid for new Enterprise UXers learning the organizational terrain; as a lightweight framework embedded in existing collaboration tools like Figma, Confluence, or Miro; or even as a role-play exercise powered by AI agents simulating typical stakeholder questions and objections. Future research could examine these formats more rigorously. For example, pre–post studies might track the time it takes to achieve stakeholder buy-in, the rate at which research-backed changes are implemented, the amount of late-stage rework avoided, or the deflection of support tickets following UX-led interventions. Such measures would make it possible to evaluate not just whether supports are appreciated, but whether they demonstrably reduce friction and improve outcomes.

Broader comparative work would also enrich this field. Replicating the inquiry outside Denmark, especially in higher power-distance cultures, could reveal whether the same patterns of influence apply or whether stakeholder dynamics differ significantly. Adding stakeholder-side interviews would provide a complementary perspective, testing whether the archetypes identified here resonate with those on the receiving end of UX advocacy. Longitudinal studies could further extend this view by examining whether consistent use of negotiation supports leads to sustained improvements over quarters or years, rather than short-term wins. The toolset itself could also be expanded. An “AI negotiation trainer” tailored for different audiences could allow UXers to rehearse conversations and practice objection handling in low-stakes environments. Similarly, an executive-brief template could standardize the way evidence is summarized for senior forums, ensuring that research effects are consistently communicated in terms of business relevance and operational impact.

Taken together, these directions highlight that UXers — especially in the present AI-inflected and economically cautious climate — must operate more strategically to safeguard their impact. This shift should not be seen merely as self-preservation. It is also a prerequisite for advancing the values associated with Industry 5.0: people-

centricity, sustainability, resilience, and competitiveness. To contribute meaningfully to this agenda, UX professionals must be able to bridge between qualitative user evidence and quantitative business signals, to engage stakeholders in ways that build trust, and to demonstrate the organizational relevance of their work.

The prototype developed here represents one route toward that goal. It is not the final word, but rather a proof of concept for how negotiation-oriented frameworks can be embedded into UX practice. Further development, testing, and adaptation of such supports appear both timely and necessary if UX is to maintain influence and actively shape the industries in which it operates.

7 Summary

This thesis explores how Enterprise UX professionals navigate stakeholder dynamics in engineering-heavy organizations, particularly in the context of AI advancements and Industry 5.0's human-centric agenda. Using an abductive research approach (Brinkmann, 2014), the project draws on semi-structured interviews, ethnographic observations, and design prototyping to investigate where UX influence emerges, how it is constrained, and what kinds of supports could strengthen it.

The Introduction situates UX at a critical juncture: while AI tools threaten to automate visible design outputs such as wireframes or UI variants, the real influence of Enterprise UX lies less in artifacts and more in negotiation, translation, and cross-functional orchestration. This aligns with Industry 5.0's emphasis on human-centered, resilient practices that extend beyond efficiency toward collaboration and care.

The Methodology builds on an abductive stance, treating "stumbling moments" as productive data points. Rather than imposing fixed hypotheses, the research evolved iteratively through interviews, literature, and practice. The design process was structured by Sanders and Stappers' (2014) co-design framework, emphasizing pre-design and generative phases, and concluded with an exploratory prototype.

The Findings highlight a layered stakeholder landscape. Collaboration was strongest with first-ring partners such as engineers, product managers, and fellow designers, where access and shared artifacts facilitated engagement. Friction appeared in second- and third-ring roles — sales, marketing, operations — where UX needed to translate evidence into concise, quantitative signals. Informal "bridge builders" emerged as crucial allies, echoing prior research on influence through relational networks. Coping strategies included layered evidence, co-ownership of synthesis, audience-specific translation, and everyday visibility work. AI was seen less as a threat to craft than as a shift in evidence expectations, raising demand for quantifiable proxies while leaving interpretive and negotiation work firmly human.

The Prototype — Enterprise UX Negotiation Cards — embodied these insights. Conceived as a probe rather than a finished tool, it offered stakeholder maps, archetypes, and preparation templates for high-stakes conversations. Its aim was to make influence more deliberate and repeatable by externalizing assumptions, aligning teams, and rehearsing tactics.

The Discussion and Conclusion argue that the future resilience of Enterprise UX depends not on outputs alone, but on strategic capabilities: negotiation, stakeholder

alignment, and organizational learning. Practical supports like the Negotiation Cards can strengthen these capabilities and better align UX with Industry 5.0 values. Future work should test such tools across different cultural contexts, integrate stakeholder perspectives, and evaluate long-term impact on adoption, rework, and operational outcomes.

Overall, the thesis positions Enterprise UX as a discipline increasingly defined by its ability to navigate complexity and sustain influence in an AI-mediated, economically cautious climate. Its contribution lies in showing how negotiation-oriented supports can help practitioners safeguard their role while advancing more human-centered organizational futures.

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9 Artificial Intelligence Use Acknowledgement

This thesis was prepared with the support of Artificial Intelligence tools (ChatGPT 4.0 and 5.0), used solely to enhance the grammar and style of the author's original text. All thoughts and interpretations, unless otherwise cited or specified, are the author's own. In addition, the interview transcripts were generated from recordings and subsequently edited with AI assistance.

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11 Attachments

11.1 Outline for the Semi-structured Interview

1. Quick Introduction (5 min)

- Your role, team setup, and product focus?
- How is UX perceived in your organization? (UX maturity)

2. Stakeholder Mapping Activity (10–15 min)

- Prompt: You've done UX research and know what should change – now who do you need to talk to?
- Collaboratively build stakeholder map in FigJam:
- Closest to furthest collaborators
- Easy / Neutral / Hard to influence
- Special tags: blockers, allies, decision-makers

3. Communicating Research (15–20 min)

- What insights do you usually share from qualitative research?
- What formats work best? (storytelling, visuals, prototypes)
- Do you adjust framing for technical/stakeholder audiences?
- Do you ever blend quant + qual insights?

4. Relationships & Influence Tactics (10–15 min)

- How do you build and maintain stakeholder relationships?
- Any informal tactics or rituals that helped build trust?
- Who do you rely on as allies?

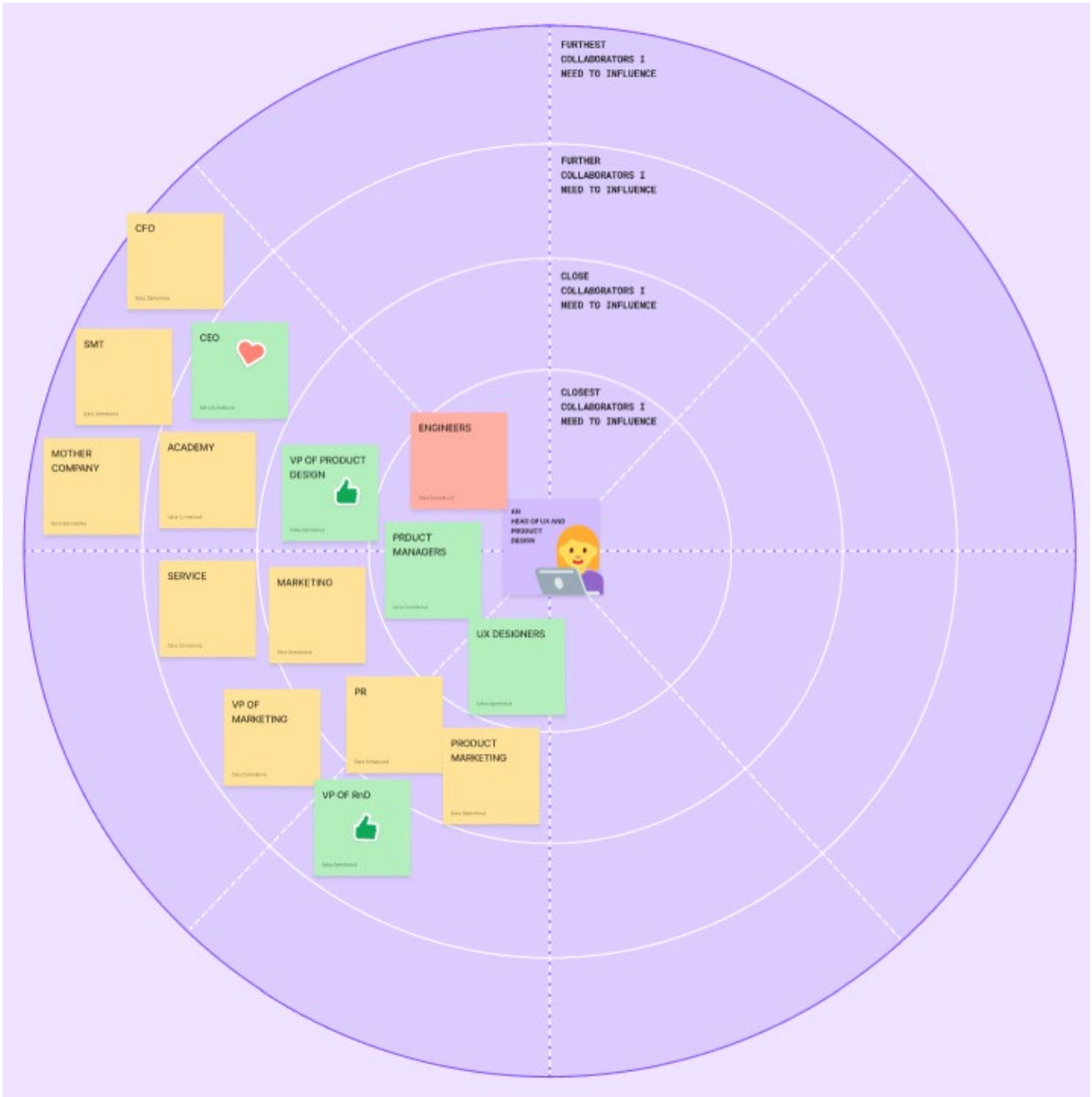
5. Strategic UX & Overcoming Barriers (10–15 min)

- Describe a time your work wasn't accepted – what happened?
- What resistance do you face, and from whom?
- How do you engage leadership or make UX part of strategy?

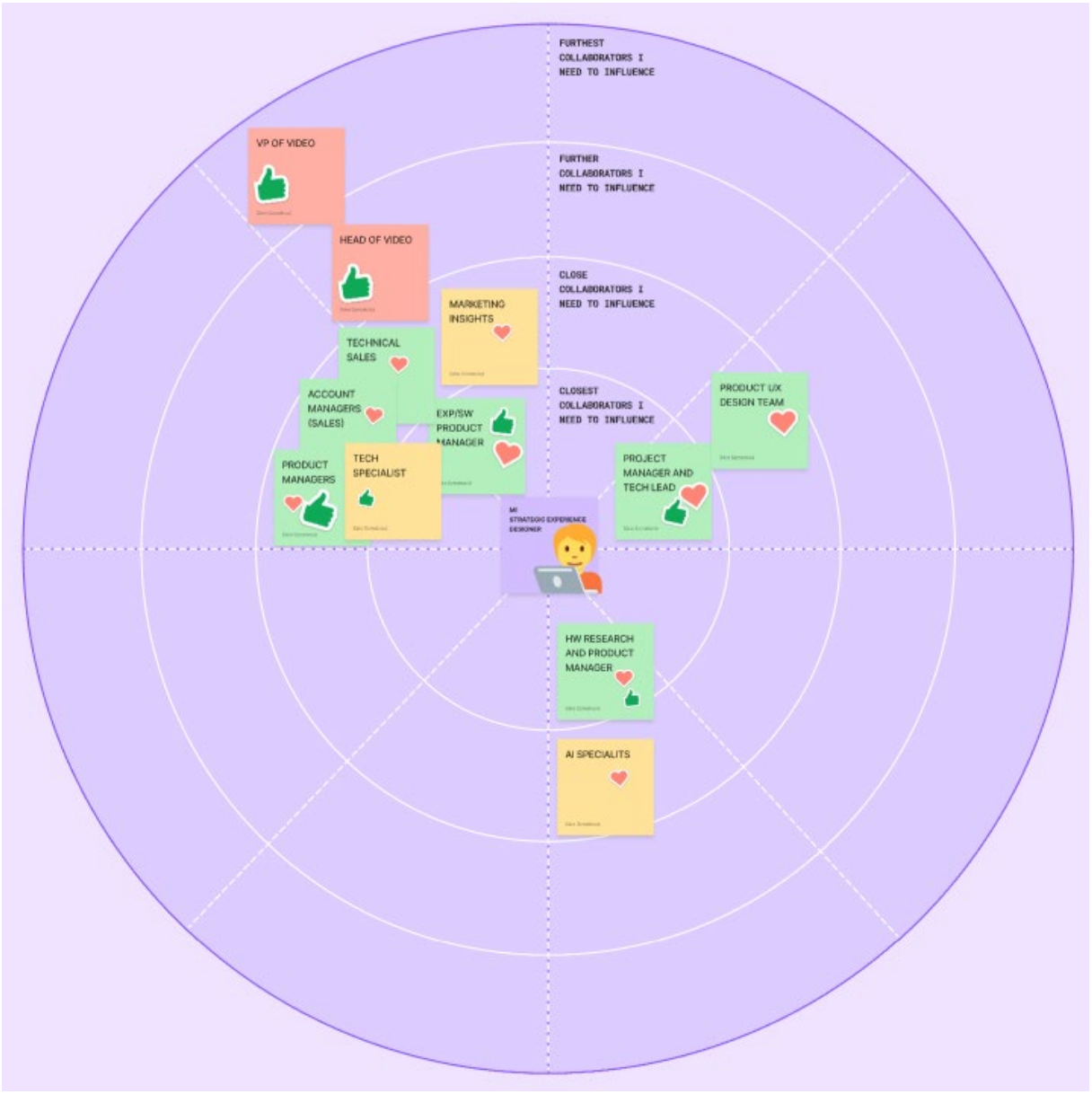
6. Wrap-Up (5 min)

- Advice to junior UXers about influence?
- Anything else important I didn't ask?
- Okay to follow up if needed?

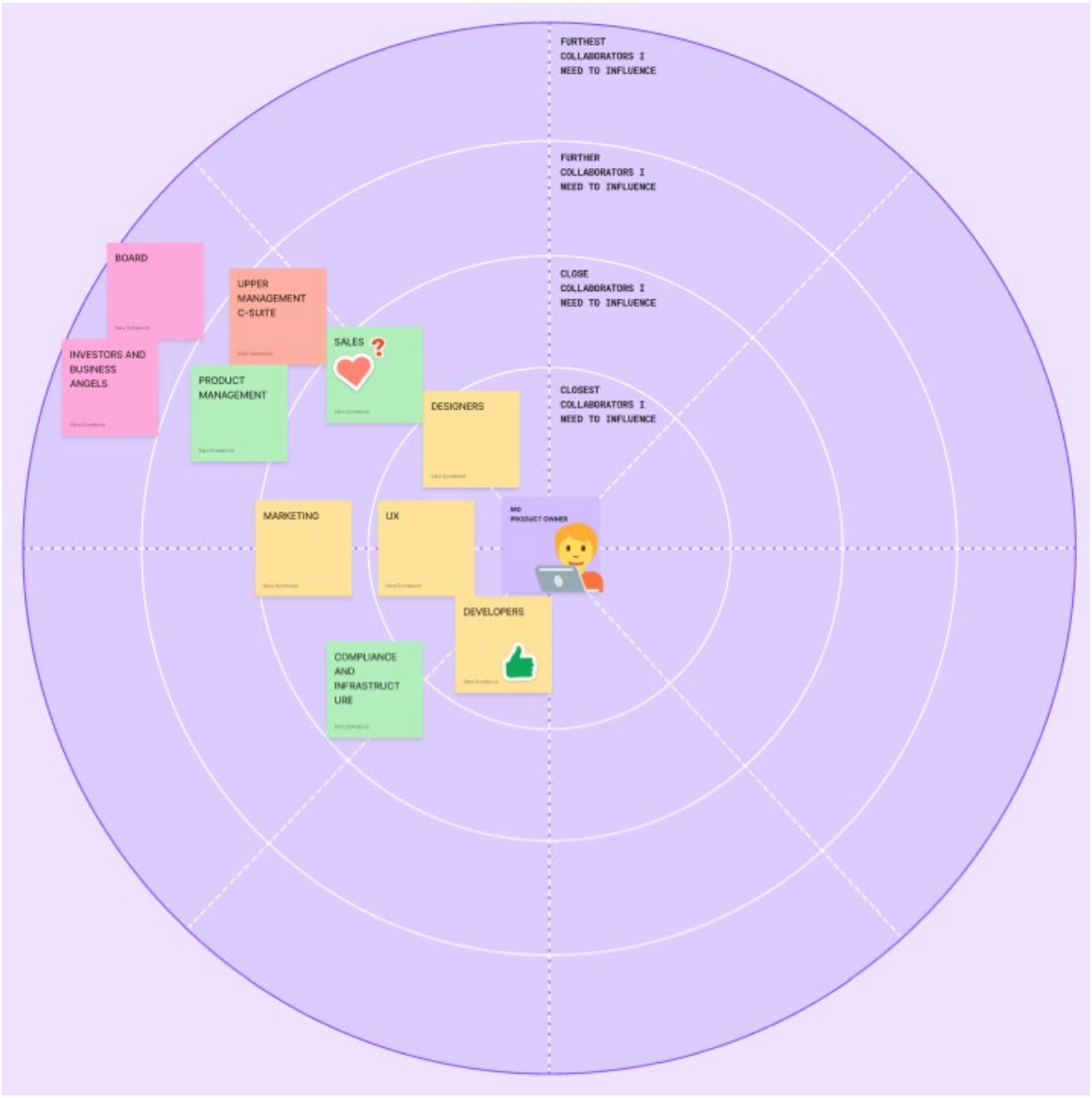
11.2 Ego-centric Map (P1)



11.3 Egocentric Map (P2)



11.4 Ego-centric Map (P3)



11.5 Ego-centric Map (P4)



11.6 Enterprise UX Negotiation Cards and AI Negotiation Trainer

Enterprise UX
Negotiation Cards

A Framework to Increase Internal Influence of Enterprise UXers

Objectives:

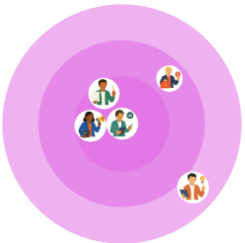
- Boost empathy towards stakeholders' goals and position inside the company.
- Collect and present the right data at the right discussions.
- Ensure higher respect and influence through speaking stakeholders' language.



Sára Szmeková, 2025

How to guide

1.



Spread your stakeholders across your map. Who do you need to influence the most? Who has the biggest say in this project? Where could the insights get lost in translation or perceived importance?

2.



Write down everything you know about each relevant stakeholder - there is an example based on my research. Afterwards, try to anticipate their answers in the second column. Think about what can you do about it in the third column.

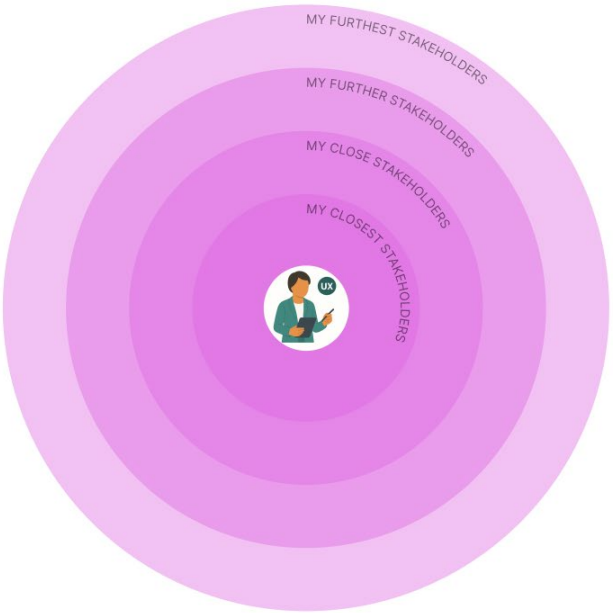
3.



Put together your result communication strategy. Are you aware of the strengths you have in the battle to defend your users?

Internal Stakeholder Mapping Activity





Sales



What do I know about them:

Typically quite extroverted and strong in verbal expressions, which makes them a valuable ally within the company. They would come with demands from the customers which can be both beneficial but reflective to how strong the company!s vision and strategy is, can skew and adapt the product too much to specific client's needs. Sales have high influence on the Senior managers and therefore overall direction, without focusing too much on the aftermath after closing a sale. They can be neglectful towards the user, especially since the user is not the one closing the deal. However, they can connect you to the right people for testing. They also carry a lot of valuable insights. Present them with metrics that are "faster" or making products "cheaper". Provide success stories they can use to convince the customers.

Them:

Goals in project:

Click here to start writing...

Motivations:

Click here to start writing...

What expressions, metrics, language do they use?

Click here to start writing...

What does perfect outcome look like to them?

Click here to start writing...

UX:

How can UX help to reach them?

Click here to start writing...

How can UX align with them?

Click here to start writing...

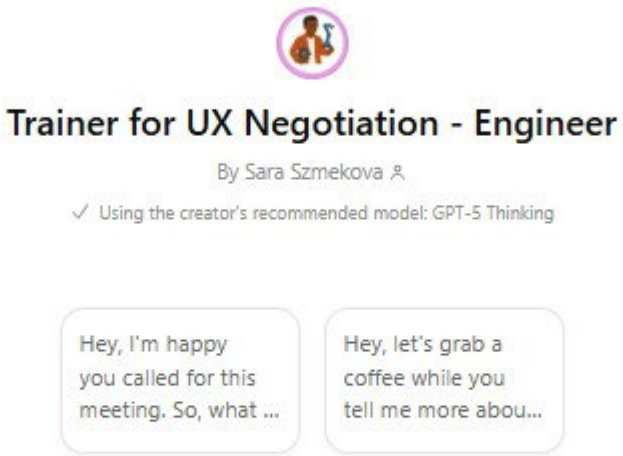
What data do I need to gather, how do I involve them or present it to them?

Click here to start writing...

What are my arguments for or against?

Click here to start writing...

Research	Data I need to gather:	Why? For what stakeholder?
Timeframe: Click here to start writing... **Problem:** Click here to start writing... **What is UX expected to deliver?** Click here to start writing... **Stakeholders:** Click here to start writing...	Click here to start writing...	Click here to start writing...



11.7 Transcript and Video Recordings of Interviews

As the interview material amounts to approximately five hours of spoken content, including full transcripts as appendices would render the thesis unnecessarily lengthy. For reasons of practicality, the transcripts are therefore not attached. However, both the video recordings and printed transcripts will be made available during the oral examination and can be consulted upon request for clarification or further inquiry.